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Assignment Title CA2

**The Influence of Digital Marketing on Consumer
Behaviour: A Study of Gen Z Purchasing Trends in
Dublin's Retail E-commerce Sector**

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Declaration

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I declare that this dissertation, submitted to Dublin Business School for the Degree of Bachelor of Arts (Honours) in Marketing, Digital Media, and Cloud Computing, is the result of my work and investigations, except where otherwise stated, as acknowledged in the references. Furthermore, this work has not been submitted for any other degree.

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Abstract

This research explores the influence of digital marketing on Generation Z's purchasing behaviour within the Irish e-commerce retail sector. (Bouet, 2024) The study focuses particularly on the roles of personalised advertising, social media platforms, and influencer marketing. (Warc, 2024) A descriptive mixed-method approach was used, combining a comprehensive literature review with primary data gathered from 166 Gen Z respondents through an online questionnaire. The findings reveal that platforms like Instagram and TikTok significantly impact Gen Z's purchasing decisions, with personalised ads increasing engagement when recognised as authentic. However, concerns about data privacy and ad trespass appear as key challenges. (Kuzminov, 2023) Brands that demonstrate transparency and align with Gen Z values were found to gain greater trust and long-term engagement. (Anderson, 2023) The study concludes by recommending that companies adopt ethical digital strategies, prioritise transparency, and collaborate with authentic influencers to better connect with this demographic.

Introduction

Digital marketing has transformed how brands interact with consumers, particularly Generation Z, a demographic known for its digital fluency and active presence on social media platforms (Chambers, 2023). In the context of retail e-commerce, platforms such as Instagram, TikTok, and Facebook have become essential marketing tools, enabling brands to reach Gen Z through personalised advertising and influencer campaigns. However, concerns regarding data privacy, brand trust, and the authenticity of influencers have made it increasingly important to understand how this generation responds to digital marketing strategies. While existing studies have explored the general online behaviour of Gen Z, there is a notable gap in understanding their attitudes and purchasing patterns within the retail e-commerce environment in Dublin,

Ireland. This study aims to address that gap by analysing both secondary literature and primary data collected through a structured online survey of 166 respondents based in Dublin, Ireland. The research focuses on the impact of personalised advertisements and social media engagement on Gen Z's purchasing behaviour, brand satisfaction, and trust. This study aims to:

1. Explore how social media platforms influence purchasing decisions among Generation Z consumers in Dublin's retail e-commerce space.
2. Investigate how personalised digital advertisements affect engagement, satisfaction, and trust in brands within the Irish Gen Z retail e-commerce environment.

Background to the Problem

Although personalised advertising has become a dominant trend on social media platforms (Kastenholz, 2021), there remains a significant gap in understanding how Generation Z perceives these ads and influencer endorsements in the context of online shopping (Lina et al., 2022). Gen Z consumers show an increasing concern about data privacy, advertising ethics, and the over-personalisation of content, which can result in feelings of intrusion and irritation rather than engagement (Ramakrishnan, 2023; Panel, 2023). These perceptions pose challenges for digital marketers aiming to connect authentically with this demographic. By addressing this gap, the present study seeks to contribute to existing research by offering new insights into Gen Z's attitudes toward personalised ads, social media influencers, and brand trust in Ireland's e-commerce environment.

Research Question:

Q1. How does digital marketing influence Generation Z's purchasing behaviour in the retail e-commerce sector in Dublin, Ireland?

Research Objectives:

OBJ1. To explore how social media platforms such as Instagram and TikTok influence purchasing decisions among Generation Z consumers in Dublin's retail e-commerce sector.

OBJ2: To investigate how personalised digital advertisements affect consumer engagement, brand satisfaction, and loyalty among Gen Z consumers in Ireland's retail e-commerce environment.

Hypothesis:

Hypothesis 1 (H1): Tailored advertising has a positive impact towards Gen Z's brand engagement and satisfaction in the retail e-commerce sector.

Hypothesis 2 (H2): Digital marketing positively influences Gen Z's purchasing behaviour, particularly when consumers are aware of how personalised ads work.

Hypothesis 3 (H3): The concerns regarding confidentiality and data usage negatively affect the engagement of Gen Z towards personalised advertising in the retail e-commerce sector.

Organisation of the Project

This research paper begins with Chapter 1, where a literature review was conducted to develop enough understanding of the topic at hand, and then Chapter 2, where the method section justifies why particular types/approaches were selected. The rationale for why other types of samples/methodology weren't chosen is also in Chapter 2, followed by Chapter 3 where the data analysis is presented, including information from the online survey as well as whether the hypotheses are supported or not. Chapter 4 is the last chapter that contains the conclusion and recommendation for this study.

Scope and Limitations of the Research Project

The study was conducted mostly on students at DBS College, involving a relatively small sample of 166 participants; thus, the results may not completely represent on a larger scale the consumer's behaviour. The absence of focus groups limits the insights and perspectives of the emotional and behaviour patterns. Furthermore, the time limit adds to the existing limitations. (Viera, 2024)

Objectives of Work

The purpose of this research is to investigate the key factors that influence Generation Z's purchasing behaviour in the context of e-commerce retail in Ireland, with a specific focus on their interactions with digital marketing strategies such as personalised advertising and social media promotions. Thus, the study sets out these 2 objectives: 1. To examine how social media platforms influence purchasing decisions among Generation Z consumers in Dublin, Ireland. 2. To explore how personalised digital advertisements affect engagement, satisfaction, and trust in brands within the Irish Gen Z retail e-commerce market.

Methodology Used

This study adopted a descriptive mixed-method research design, integrating both qualitative and quantitative data collection methods (NU, 2025). As primary data, an online questionnaire was used to gather insights into personalised advertising, social media influence, and brand engagement among Generation Z consumers in Dublin, Ireland. The survey contained 15 carefully designed questions, incorporating a combination of open- and closed-ended questions, multiple-choice options, and a Likert scale to capture both statistical patterns and individual perspectives. The questionnaire was distributed via social media platforms such as Instagram and WhatsApp groups, allowing for efficient access to a broad and relevant sample of Generation Z respondents.

Main Findings

The findings from the literature review and primary research highlight the significant role of digital marketing in shaping Generation Z's purchasing behaviour in Ireland's e-commerce sector. Personalised advertising and social media platforms—particularly Instagram and TikTok—were found to be key drivers of brand interaction and consumer trust. The study identified a clear research gap in understanding the long-term impact of personalised digital strategies on Gen Z brand loyalty. While short-term engagement is high, further research is needed to evaluate sustained behavioural change. Primary data gathered through the online survey reinforced these insights: 62.4% of respondents reported being influenced by online advertisements, and 49.7% considered personalised ads to be effective in shaping their purchasing decisions. These results indicate a strong preference for targeted, relevant content but also highlight underlying concerns related to data privacy and the authenticity of advertising.

Recommendations

Recommendations for future studies, brands and marketers are based on the survey questionnaire conducted as primary research and the literature review findings as secondary research. The recommendations include brand transparency, refining personalised ads, and ensuring authenticity from influencers; in addition, brands should reduce the frequency of ads when targeting Gen Z in Dublin, Ireland, to prevent tiredness and improve engagement. These suggestions aim to support more effective and ethical digital marketing strategies targeting this demographic.

Chapter 1 Literature Review



1.1. Introduction

In recent years, digital marketing has significantly evolved how consumers interact with brands, particularly Generation Z, a demographic deeply immersed in online culture (Salam et al., 2024). Gen Z, known for digital fluency, prefers online interactions via social media, personalised advertising, and peer validation like reviews (Salam et al., 2024). These developments have notably impacted the retail e-commerce sector, especially in Dublin, where digital engagement is a key driver of consumer behaviour (Gharib, 2024). This review analyses the influence of social media, personalised ads, influencer marketing, and digital ethics on Gen Z's brand engagement and purchasing behaviour.

Although previous research offers valuable insights, less is known about the long-term effects on retail e-commerce decision-making and strategies. This chapter establishes the theoretical foundation for the research and contextualises Gen Z's evolving relationship with digital marketing.

1.2. Gen Z as Digital Natives in E-Commerce Retail Fashion

1.2.1. Key Characteristics of Gen Z as Digital Natives

Generation Z, born between the mid-1990s and early 2010s, are recognised as digital natives due to their early and continuous exposure to digital technologies. They prefer mobile-first experiences and navigate online platforms with ease (Chang et al., 2023). Their behaviour has been shaped by growing up with the internet, social media, and e-commerce (Jayatissa & Dimani, (2023); Wang (2023) and Astuti et al. (2024) note that Gen Z often shops online via mobile devices, finding inspiration from platforms like Instagram, TikTok, and Facebook. In Ireland, this group values the convenience and speed of e-commerce (Consultants, 2023). They also enjoy interactive shopping features, such as augmented reality (AR) and virtual try-on (VTO) tools, which offer entertainment and social interaction during the purchasing process (Kovács & Keresztes, 2024).

1.2.2. The Role of Social Media in Shaping Gen Z's E-Commerce Behavior

Gen Z in Ireland mostly uses Instagram, TikTok, and Facebook, and these platforms play a big role in what they buy. Ads, influencer content, and reviews often shape their decisions (Astuti et al., 2024; Syah & Salim, 2024; Basiony, 2024). They prefer quick, eye-catching content, and that fits with how these platforms work (Garg & Gopal, 2024). In Ireland alone, Instagram has more than 2.4 million users, so positive feedback there can boost trust (Basiony, 2024). Reviews and word of mouth help build trust (Muchlis & Djawoto, 2024; Rahmah et al., 2023). While Gen Z is becoming more aware of ethical and sustainable practices, price and value still play a major role in their purchase choices. (Rahmah et al., 2023; Balińska et al., 2024).

1.3.The Impact of Personalized Advertising on Gen Z's Brand Engagement

Personalized advertising has become known as an effective digital marketing strategy, particularly for Generation Z, a cohort characterised by its digital fluency, individualism, and preference for tailored experiences. (Reddy et al., 2024) This constant exposure to technology generates significant changes in the individual's behaviour and, as a result, their consumption patterns (Katz et al., 2021). Utilizing data-driven insights and artificial intelligence (AI), brands can deliver ads that align with consumers' interests and behaviours, increasing relevance and engagement (Reddy et al., 2024). For Gen Z, such ads can cultivate deeper brand engagement by creating a sense of recognition and connection. However, hyper-targeted content may lead to privacy concerns, reduced trust, and advertising fatigue, especially when ads appear too frequently or feel manipulative (Reddy et al., 2024; Salam et al., 2024). While personalised advertising can enhance brand loyalty, it must be used with transparency and ethical data practices to maintain consumer trust. (Salam et al., 2024)

1.3.1. Positive Impacts of Personalized Advertising on Gen Z's Brand Engagement

For Generation Z, personalised advertising can feel more relevant and engaging because it reflects their individual preferences. This type of tailored content makes it easier for consumers to form stronger emotional bonds with brands, encouraging repeat interaction and longer-term loyalty (Astuti & Putra, 2023; Kumar & Sharma, 2022).

1.3.2. Increased Relevance and Engagement

Gen Z consumers are more likely to engage with ads tailored to their needs and preferences; research by Astuti and Putra (2023) notes that personalisation improves relevance, increasing brand interaction. Tran et al. (2022) also found that personalised ads create stronger emotional ties, making the brand feel more relatable. Basiony (2024) reports that in Ireland, about 4.02 million social media users are influenced by ad timing, relevance, and format—all of which impact their purchasing decisions.

1.3.3. Building Brand Loyalty

Generation Z tends to appreciate independence, but they also connect with brands that make them feel seen. When ads are personalised and product suggestions feel relevant, it helps build emotional bonds, which, over time, can lead to brand loyalty (Syaputra & Azhar, 2025). In the fashion industry, researchers have found that customised social media marketing often leads to stronger feelings of "Brand Love", a key driver in building long-term loyalty (Linh, Ha & Loan, 2024)

1.3.4. Emotional Attachment and Trust

Personalised advertising strengthens emotional bonds, especially on platforms like Instagram and Facebook. Syaputra & Azhar (2025) and Tran et al. (2022) found Gen Z forms deeper connections with brands when content aligns with their preferences. Basiony (2024) notes strong engagement from female users on Instagram. AI-driven personalisation also improves brand trust, a key factor in Gen Z's buying decisions (Guerra-Tamez et al., 2024).

1.3.5. Influence of Influencers and Authenticity

Harrigan et al. (2021) define Social Media Influencers – SMIs as individuals who create content for social media platforms and engage many followers with their shared ideas. Influencer marketing plays an important role in shaping Gen Z’s engagement and trust in brands. A study by Baghel (2023) found that personalised influencer advertising—where the product naturally fits the influencer’s usual content and audience—leads to higher engagement and enhances the perceived authenticity of the message. This demographic is particularly sensitive to the perceived authenticity of marketing content and prefers influencers whose values, lifestyle, and content align with their own.

Table 1. Good Practices for Personalized Advertising (Based on the Literature Review)

Practice	Description	Citation
Respect Consumer Privacy	Brands should clearly explain how they use data and allow users to control their preferences.	(Lee et al., 2024).
Use AI Responsibly	AI-powered personalization should improve experiences, not feel invasive.	(Dogan, 2024)
Keep It Authentic	Ads should match the consumer’s lifestyle and avoid aggressive targeting.	(Baghel, 2023)
Test Ad Frequency	Brands should limit overexposure to avoid annoying consumers.	(Nikiforov, 2023)
Be Transparent	Gen Z trusts brands that communicate openly about how their ads work.	(Tran et al., 2022)

1.4. Influencers and User-Generated Content in Gen Z's Purchasing Decisions

One such method of social media marketing is influencer marketing. Influencers are digital content creators that are defined by an online following, a distinctive brand persona and a patterned relationship with a commercial sponsor (Duffy & Erin, 2020). Influencer marketing is widely used by marketing firms to promote their business. In 2023 the influencer marketing had a value of 21.1 billion US dollars (Statista, 2024). Influencer marketing is used by businesses to cultivate trust and engage with consumers more effectively (Tato et al., 2025), although there is currently debate in literature on the effectiveness of influencers on purchase decisions for the consumer (Hidayatullah et al., 2025). Credibility and trust are crucial for influencers as they rely on a positive public image to be effective. If an influencer is perceived as being closely controlled by the brands, consumers will treat the information like a violation in the consumer-influencer relationship, triggering negative feelings in the consumer (Pradhan et al., 2022). However, if an influencer can effectively align with a brand's domain, this will make the brand's message more effective and improve their followers' perception of a brand (Leung et al., 2022).

User-generated content (UGC) can be defined as media content generated by people outside of media institutions, made available to the public typically at no cost (Bolin, 2021) while having similar effects on consumers. It differs from influencer marketing significantly, as Influencer marketing is owned and regulated by the business (Anderson, 2025). One key form of UGC is reviews and testimonials. Typically divided into structured, with numerical rankings and unstructured, with textual reviews (Santos, 2021). Studies show that product evaluations from third-party platforms will increase the purchase intention of a consumer (Jia et al., 2023).

1.5. Transparency and Ethical Digital Marketing Practices for Gen Z

Gen Z consumers are more aware and well-informed about how brands handle their data compared to older generations. (Hoang et al. 2022) The confidentiality and moral aspect that comes with it are values that Gen Z cares about; thus, when a brand isn't transparent about how it collects and uses data, Gen Z often loses trust and leaves that brand (Balungcas, 2023). This section focuses on how transparency and ethical choices affect their trust and loyalty.

1.5.1. Challenges & Risks of Personalized Advertising

Even though personalized advertising may increase relevance, it can also present risks when it is used wrongfully. (Balungcas, 2023) Research by Dahl & Peltier(2023) mentioned that over-targeting can make Gen Z consumers feel like they are constantly monitored, which will lead to feelings of discomfort, thus reducing trust. Research by Hoang et al. (2022) and Dahl & Peltier (2023) found that brands which are not transparent about how the data is collected often experience backlash and reduced customer loyalty. The difficulty lies in offering relevance without feeling intrusive.

1.5.2. Data Transparency & Consumer Trust

Transparency plays a critical role in building consumer trust; according to Dahl and Peltier (2023), brands that are transparent and explain their data collection and usage policies are more likely to retain Gen Z customers as trust brands that are honest and upfront. On the other hand, those brands that use hidden methods of retaining and tracking information will backlash and be confronted with negative reactions. (Dahl & Peltier 2023)

1.5.3. Informed Consent & Privacy Controls

Studies from Vincent (2025) have shown that Gen Z wants more control over their data, and brands that offer them this option will gain their trust. In case these users feel forced by circumstances to share unwanted data, they will retreat and avoid any future connection with these brands. (Dahl & Peltier, 2023)

1.5.4. Authenticity & Ethical Influencer Marketing

Gen Z can easily tell when influencers promote products just for money; according to Baghel (2023), brands that work with influencers who reflect their values perform better. Fake endorsements damage credibility and turn consumers away (Guerra-Tamez et al., 2024). While Gen Z values personalised content, they also expect brands to respect their privacy (Nikiforov, 2023). Thakkar (2024) warns that if brands make ethical claims without proof, Gen Z will call them out. In Ireland, Basiony (2024) notes that partnerships with genuine influencers that reflect local trends can help boost engagement and sales.

Table 2, Good Practices for Ethical Marketing (Based on the Literature Review)

Practice	Description	Citation
Be Transparent	Clearly explain how consumer data is collected and used.	(Lee et al., 2024)
Give Users Control	Provide options to customize ad preferences and opt out of tracking.	(Vincent, 2025)
Choose Authentic Influencers	Work with influencers who genuinely believe in the brand.	(Baghel, 2023)
Avoid Clickbait & Manipulative Ads	Ensure advertising matches actual brand values	(Thakkar, 2024)
Commit to Real Ethical Practices	Follow through on ethical promises to build long-term consumer trust.	(Hoang et al., 2022)

1.6. Conclusion

This literature review highlighted that Gen Z connects with brands through personalised ads, especially when the content matches their interests. However, if ads feel too targeted or invasive, trust begins to fade. This generation values transparency, honesty, and control over how their data is used as well, and this generation relies on social media, influencer opinions, and online reviews when making decisions, which has changed how e-commerce works today. Brands that are clear about their data use, work with real influencers, and stay true to their values are more likely to earn Gen Z's loyalty over time.

Chapter 2 Methodology



2.1. Introduction

This chapter will present the research approach used in order to explore how digital marketing affects Gen Z's buying behaviour in Dublin's retail e-commerce sector. A descriptive mixed-methods approach was chosen to collect both numerical data and personal opinions. This approach allowed for a better understanding of overall patterns and individual perspectives. The chapter also outlines the survey design, sampling process, and how the data was analysed in relation to the study's objectives.

Research Question:

How does digital marketing influence Generation Z's purchasing behaviour in the retail e-commerce sector in Dublin, Ireland?

Research Objectives:

OBJ1: To explore how social media platforms such as Instagram and TikTok influence purchasing decisions among Generation Z consumers in Dublin's retail e-commerce sector.

OBJ2: To investigate how personalised digital advertisements affect consumer engagement, brand satisfaction, and loyalty among Gen Z consumers in Ireland's retail e-commerce environment.

Research Hypothesis:

Hypothesis 1 (H1): Tailored advertising has a positive impact towards Gen Z's brand engagement and satisfaction in the retail e-commerce sector.

Hypothesis 2 (H2): Digital marketing positively influences Gen Z's purchasing behaviour, particularly when consumers are aware of how personalised ads work.

Hypothesis 3 (H3): The concerns regarding confidentiality and data usage negatively affect the engagement of Gen Z towards personalised advertising in the retail e-commerce sector.

2.2. Research Design Strategy

Donegan and Fleming (2007) define research design as the structure connecting methods to study goals. This study used a descriptive mixed-method design, combining quantitative and qualitative approaches to understand how digital marketing affects Gen Z's purchasing behaviour in Dublin's retail e-commerce sector (Gabelaia & Tracy, 2025). The quantitative side offered measurable insights, while the qualitative data revealed motivations and preferences. The dual-method approach provided insights into both the observable behaviours and the motivations driving them in response to digital marketing efforts.

2.3. Alternative Research Methods

Other research methods like exploratory research, case studies, interviews, focus groups, and causal research were excluded due to limitations. Exploratory research suits newer topics, but digital marketing and Gen Z are already well-studied. Case studies and interviews are time-consuming and less suitable for large, diverse samples. Causal research seeks to prove cause-and-effect, which was not the focus here. The chosen descriptive mixed-method approach provided both broad data and deeper insight, making it more appropriate for this study (Privitera, 2025).

2.4. Primary and Secondary Research

Primary research was done by creating and sharing an online survey questionnaire designed for Gen Z consumers. This survey collected both numbers (ratings and multiple-choice answers) and written responses, giving us a deeper understanding of how Gen Z thinks and feels about digital marketing. (Nanda Asma Wati, 2025)

We chose an online questionnaire because it was quick, easy to use, and ideal for connecting with Gen Z, who spend a lot of time online. It allowed for quick distribution, broad reach, and anonymous responses, which encouraged honesty. This approach was also economical and manageable within the limited timeframe of the study.

Questionnaires are time- and cost-efficient, allowing for data collection from a large group quickly. The standardised format ensures consistency, and anonymity can lead to more honest responses. Although efficient, questionnaires may fail to capture deeper insights, and the lack

of researcher interaction increases the risk of misunderstanding. Some responses may also be incomplete or rushed.

Secondary Research involved a literature review of existing academic publications, industry reports, and market analyses related to digital marketing strategies, Gen Z consumer behaviour, and the role of technology in e-commerce. They provided the foundation for constructing a framework to interpret the primary data. (Salam et al., 2024) (Gharib, 2024)

Secondary data is useful for providing background information and saves time and resources. Still, it might be old, not fully related to the study, and cannot be adjusted. The researcher also can't control how it was gathered or how accurate it is.

2.5. Quantitative and Qualitative Research

This study used a descriptive mixed-methods approach to explore how digital marketing affects Gen Z's e-commerce behaviour. The quantitative part of the research focused on collecting clear, structured data. This made it possible to see how things like ads are linked to decisions to buy. For example, participants were asked to rate how likely they were to interact with a brand after seeing a personalised ad, using a scale from 1 to 5. (Salam, 2024)

The qualitative component used open-ended questions to explore participants' personal experiences, attitudes, and perceptions related to influencer marketing, social media promotions, and online shopping habits. These responses were later coded and thematically analysed to extract meaningful patterns. (Hodžić, 2025)

2.6 Research Tool Selected

The researchers in this study chose to use a questionnaire method for their primary research and conducted a literature review as secondary research to enhance their comprehension of the topic. The survey was created using Google Forms because it's mobile-friendly and easy for Gen Z to access (Silva, 2024). It included five short parts: Demographics – Age, gender, location- showed online shopping habits. Brand Engagement – Questions on ads, loyalty, and satisfaction. Purchase Decisions – Influence of sponsored posts, reviews, and influencers. Social Media – How TikTok and Instagram Affect Brand Perception. Open-ended questions- Share personal thoughts and real-life examples related to digital marketing interactions.

2.7. Fieldwork

The survey was carried out over 40 days, giving enough time to collect a wide range of responses from different types of people. It was shared through Instagram Stories, direct messages, and WhatsApp groups. By using these popular platforms, we were able to reach more Gen Z users who spend a lot of time online. (Silva, 2024)

2.8. Profile of Respondents

A total of 166 Gen Z participants (ages 18–27) responded who regularly engage in online shopping and use digital platforms daily. The participant group consisted of students, young professionals, and active social media users from various parts of Ireland, with a strong representation from urban centres like Dublin. The diversity in geographic location and lifestyle habits provided a broad perspective on Gen Z's interaction with digital marketing. (Maheswari, 2025)

2.9. Sampling Method

Participants were chosen through convenience sampling, based on how easy they were to reach and their willingness to participate. (Alsaadi, 2024)

Convenience sampling was chosen because of limited time and resources. It allowed easy access to Gen Z participants who are active online and familiar with digital marketing. While it may reduce generalisability, it was effective for gathering relevant insights from the target group.

Sampling Type

The non-random sampling type was chosen due to the nature of the topic and the limited timeframe of the research project. It allowed for fast data collection from people who actively use social media and understand digital ads. (Silva, 2024)

While this approach has some limitations in terms of generalisability, it was appropriate for gathering exploratory insights from digitally engaged users, who were the intended focus of the study.

2.10. Data Analysis

Data analysis was conducted using both quantitative and qualitative methods:

Descriptive Statistics: Used to summarise demographic profiles and frequency of responses. This included average shopping frequency, most-used social platforms, and typical ad interactions.

Inferential Statistics: Applied to identify relationships between key variables—e.g., if individuals exposed to more personalised ads were more likely to report brand loyalty or satisfaction.

Thematic Analysis: All open-ended responses were coded and analysed for recurring themes. These included the perceived authenticity of influencers, distrust of overly targeted ads, and the emotional appeal of brand storytelling on social platforms.

This analytical approach provided a well-rounded view of both behavioural trends and underlying psychological drivers in the Gen Z market.

Chapter 3 Data Analysis



3.1. Introduction

This chapter will present the findings from the online Questionnaire, and the data collected will offer perspective on their interaction with digital marketing strategies in the retail e-commerce of Gen Z's consumers in Dublin, Ireland. The data collected will reveal trends and behaviours in their shopping towards personalized ads, their trust in the influencers and the role of social media platforms in shaping their purchasing decision. These results will be analysed and revised together with the Literature review to identify any correlations and bring evidence which will support or contest the Objectives and Hypothesis stated.

3.2. Research Objective 1

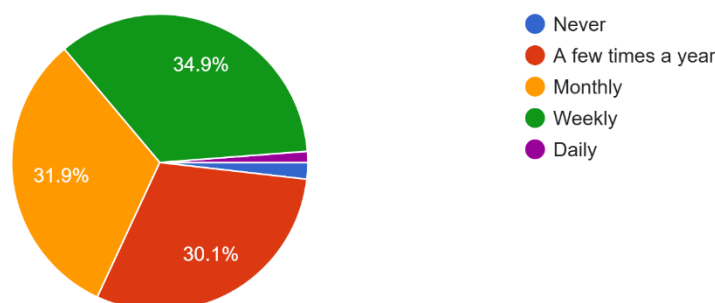
To explore how social media platforms such as Instagram and TikTok influence purchasing decisions among Generation Z consumers in Dublin's retail e-commerce sector.

The answers to Questions 4, 9, and 10 confirm that social media is a key channel that influences Irish Gen Z's buying behaviour. These platforms are central to how they discover new trends, products, and brands. This supports Lapidus et al. (2024), who noted Gen Z's reliance on social media for shopping decisions. Our data of 72.7% respondents that confirmed social media recommendations and online reviews on platforms like Instagram and TikTok are reinforcing the connection of social media and consumer decisions in fashion, beauty, and lifestyle purchases—also reflected in Baghel's (2023) findings. (See Appendix 2, Questionnaire for more details)

Figure 1, Question 4. Online Questionnaire

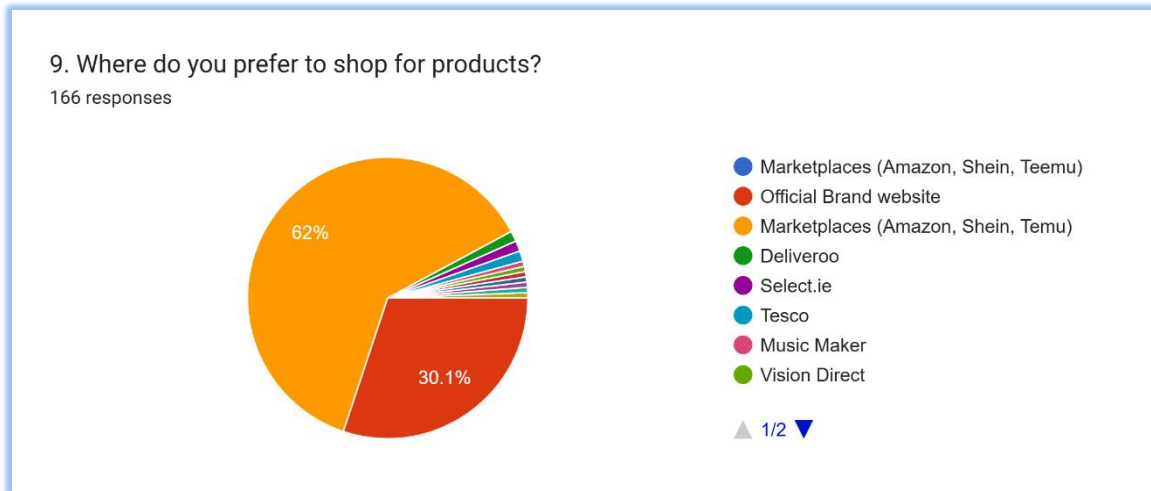
4. How often do you shop online?

166 responses



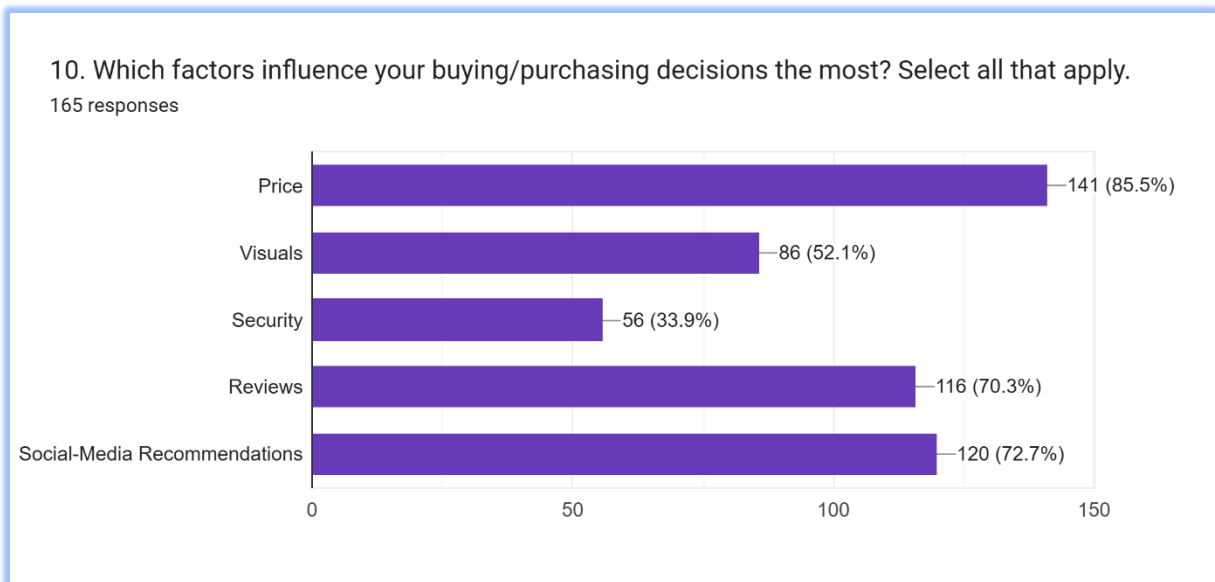
The weekly frequency of online shopping percentage of 34.9% indicates a high engagement in online shopping that is linked to social media and digital marketing strategies, matching Gen Z frequent shopping.

Figure 2, Question 9, Online Survey



The majority of 62% prefer marketplaces and e-commerce platforms where they purchase beauty products to fashion items and have access to online reviews were 30.1% shop from the official website of the brand, showing a strong preference to shop online rather than in person.

Figure 3, Question 10, Online Survey



In these data, over 70% of respondents agree that their social media platforms' recommendations, visuals (52.1%), and reviews (70.3%) have the most impact/effect when deciding to purchase online products, thus influencing their purchasing decision and playing a critical role.

3.2. Research Objective 2:

To investigate how personalised digital advertisements affect consumer engagement, brand satisfaction, and loyalty among Gen Z consumers in Ireland’s retail e-commerce environment.

Survey results to Questions 11, 12, 13, and 15 show that personalised ads have a strong impact on Gen Z’s engagement and satisfaction. Many respondents said that ads that matched their interests helped them feel more connected to brands. Many of the respondents communicated a positive reaction to advertising (62.4%) from open-ended responses highlighting discomfort when the ads felt tiring or intrusive, which suggests a pressure between these two: relevance and personal boundaries. This supports Syaputra & Azhar (2025), who found that tailored advertising boosts emotional connection and brand trust. Nevertheless, privacy was a major concern as some participants felt uncomfortable when ads seemed too intrusive or appeared excessive. This reflects the “personalisation vs privacy” issue mentioned in the literature by Dahl and Peltier (2023), where it was noted that while Gen Z values relevance, they also expect transparency and control over their data.

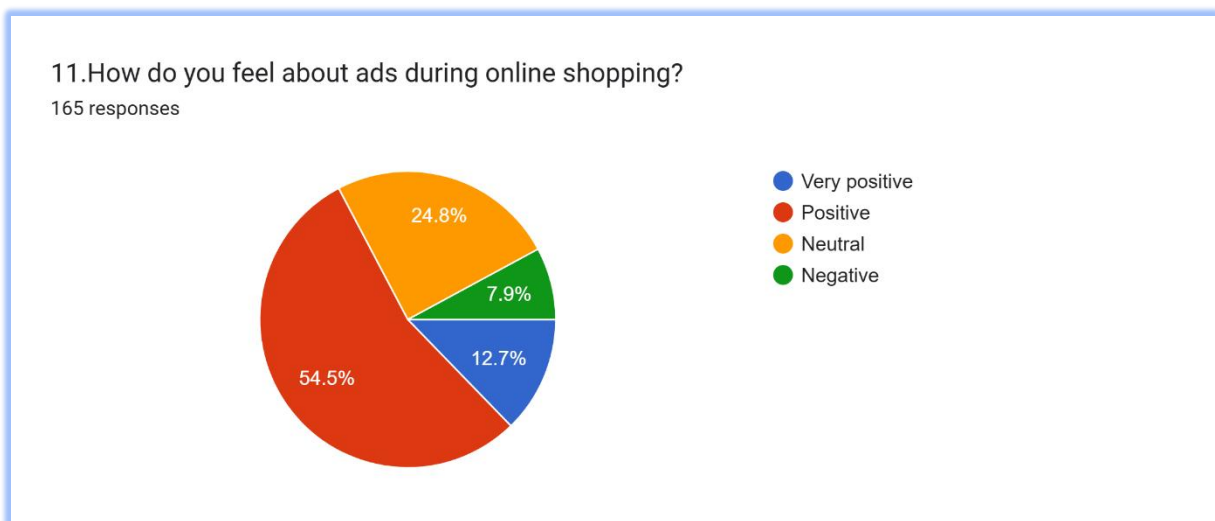
These results suggest that brands must find a balance, offering personalised experiences while respecting their privacy.

Figure 4, Question 13



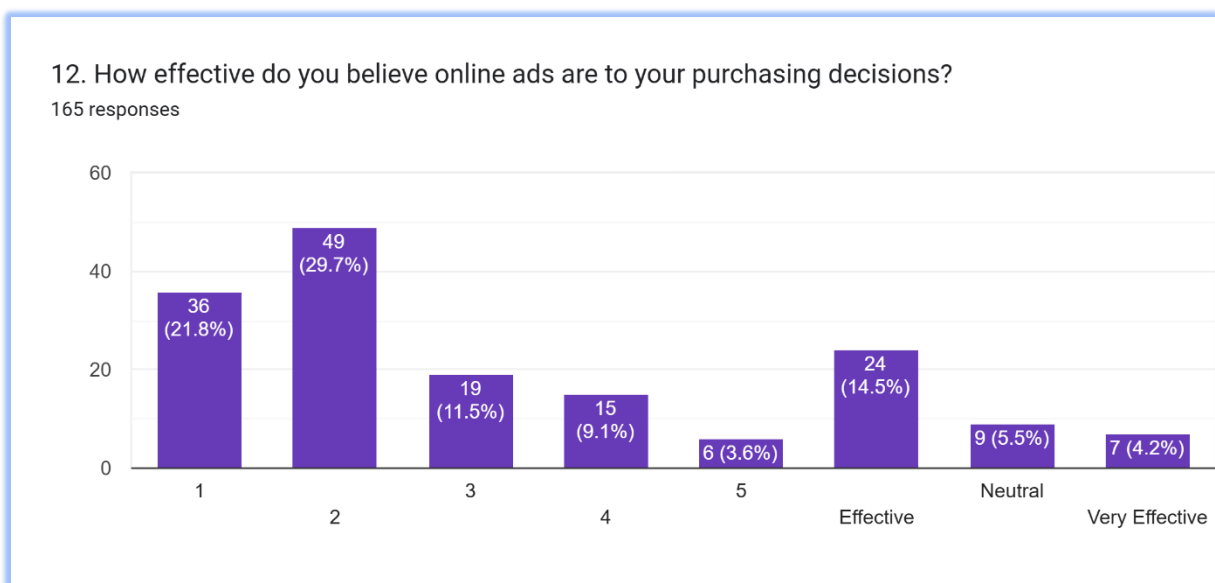
The majority of 62.4% respondents are influenced by ads when purchasing online.

Figure 5, Question 11



Respondents have mixed feelings towards ads, while the majority of 54.5% have a positive reaction towards ads.

Figure 6, Question 12

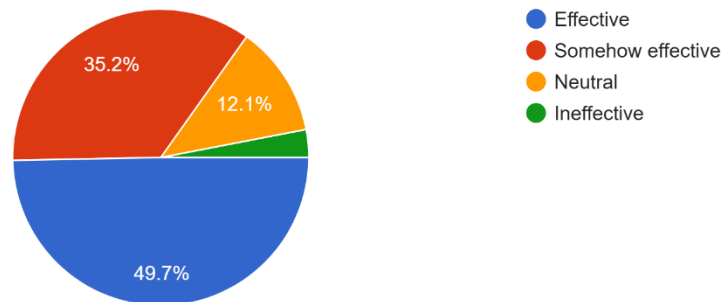


The data shows that 44.2% of respondents consider personalised ads to be effective, while 26% of respondents agree that personalised ads are very effective.

Figure 7, Question 15

15. How effective do you find personalised ads in your opinion?

165 responses



The majority of 49.7% respondents consider personalised ads to be effective. While these positive percentage indicates the effectiveness of personalised ads, it must be considered that careful implementation is needed to avoid negative reactions.

3.4. Research Hypothesis

Hypothesis 1 (H1): Tailored advertising has a positive impact towards Gen Z's brand engagement and satisfaction in retail e-commerce.

This hypothesis is partially supported. The data that comes from Q.4 and Q.7 confirms the increased satisfaction and engagement when these personalised ads correspond with their preferences and interests, while excessive ads lead to negative responses. Response data from Q.12 revealed/indicated concern towards excessive and intrusive ads and that overall satisfaction is limited and diminishes as these excessive marketing tactics raise privacy concerns. The Literature review by Tran et al. (2022) confirms that these personalized ads indicate that Gen Z appreciate commodity and relevance but, at the same time, remains sceptical towards the excessive way of marketing strategies.

Hypothesis 2 (H2): Digital marketing positively influences Gen Z's purchasing behaviour, particularly when consumers are aware of how personalised ads work.

This hypothesis is sustained by Literature review and Survey Data. The Survey results from Q.10 and Q.11 confirm that the awareness and knowledge of personalised ads increase the satisfaction and engagement on the platforms. According to research by Guerra-Tamez et al.(2024) further sustain this affirmation, showing that Gen Z respondents in mode positive when brands explain and show how their data is being used.

Hypothesis 3 (H3): The concerns regarding confidentiality and data usage negatively affect the engagement of Gen Z towards personalised advertising in the retail e-commerce sector.

These Hypothesis is supported by Survey Data and Literature review. In the open-ended Question 14, where respondents had to answer what challenge they face when shopping online, most of the answers revealed discomfort when ads felt intrusive and manipulative. These reflect and are backed up by the Literature review by Dahl & Peltier (2023), which emphasized that the privacy concerns increase in number and influence more and more of Gen Z's digital interactions.

Chapter 4 Conclusion and Recommendations



4.1. Conclusion

This study examined how digital marketing strategies, especially personalised ads and social media, shape the buying behaviour of Gen Z in Dublin's retail e-commerce space. The study also explored the trustworthiness of Gen Z in the influencers, brand engagement and their concerns towards confidentiality when purchasing online.

The findings from primary data, Q4 & Q10, demonstrated that Gen Z consumers are highly influenced by marketing strategies through platforms like Instagram and TikTok. This fact was confirmed as well by secondary data by Lapidus et al. (2024) stated that this generation relies on visuals and interactive content when deciding to buy. The attention of this generation is effectively captured by personalized ads that align with their interest, manifesting a greater engagement and interest when these succeed. (Syaputra & Azhar, 2025) Furthermore, Gen Z's preference for social media and visual content, influencer recommendations and reviews that come with these depend on discovering products and trends models and influence their purchasing choices. Nevertheless, this generation is aware and concerned about marketing tactics, which sometimes can be excessive and showcase concern regarding privacy data. (Dahl and Peltier, 2023)

The Survey results from Q14 indicated that even though personalized ads show more engagement, the respondents specified and showed concern when a certain line was crossed, and the marketing felt more intrusive or felt manipulative by it. On the other hand, despite this concern, data from Q15 also revealed that Gen Z appreciate transparency, and the brands that explain how they use their data gain loyalty and thrust. These results align with research from the Literature review of Guerra-Tamez et al. (2024) and Dahl & Peltier (2023) that stated and enhanced the balance between personalised ads and data confidentiality as a critical factor to gain the consumer trust.

Even though this study offers an important perspective, it is important to understand its limitations. This research was exclusively conducted with Gen Z respondents that currently live in Dublin, mostly students at DBS College, involving a relatively small sample of 166 participants; thus, the results may not completely represent on a larger scale the consumer's behaviour. The absence of focus groups limits the insights and perspectives of the emotional and behaviour patterns. Furthermore, the time limit adds to these limitations of these research as furthermore investigations of Gen Zs in the long-term loyalty and behaviour after the purchase was made.

4.2. Recommendations

For brands to improve their marketing strategies and increase engagement with Gen Z in the retail e-commerce space or future studies, they should consider a few aspects based on the findings:

Prioritize Transparency - Survey responses to Question 14 indicated that concerns regarding data privacy are a major barrier to trust among Gen Z consumers. This finding is supported by Dahl and Peltier (2023), who emphasise the importance of transparency in marketing. Brands should clearly communicate how consumer data is collected, used, and stored. Transparent practices can help reduce privacy-related scepticism, enhance brand trust, and improve long-term customer retention.

Personalized Ads - Primary data from Questions 11 and 15 revealed that while Gen Z consumers respond positively to personalised ads that reflect their preferences, there is a concern rise beyond which these ads feel intrusive. This is consistent with the findings of Syaputra and Azhar (2025), who suggest that well-targeted ads can foster emotional connection and brand loyalty. Brands are advised to find that balance with respect for privacy by delivering ads that are engaging but non-invasive, especially on platforms like Instagram and TikTok.

Reducing ad frequency - Primary Data Q12 and Q13 and secondary Data by Nikiforov (2023) showed us that when an ad is used excessively, it creates frustration and fatigue. Marketers should consider these findings and reduce the frequency of ads to avoid any frustration and consumers feeling overwhelmed while still running effective and relevant campaigns.

Authentic Influencers -The Survey feedback from Q10 & Q14 showed us that influencers have a major role in Gen Z purchasing decisions, as these facts are supported as well by secondary research from Baghel (2023). Collaborating only with influencers that align with brand value, influencers that are perceived authentic by Gen Z. In conclusion, this study highlights the complex relationship between Generation Z and digital marketing in the retail e-commerce space. While personalisation and influencer engagement drive strong brand interactions, ethical concerns, particularly around data usage and transparency, remain focused. Brands that balance authentic engagement with ethical data practices are more likely to build long-term trust and loyalty among Gen Z consumers in Ireland.

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APPENDIX

Appendix 1, Editing of Questionnaire

Questionnaire 15, Question 1. What is your Gender?

On the online Questionnaire, this question received 163 responses, with the majority of respondents female (59.6%), followed by male (38.6%), and a small percentage identified as prefer not to say (1.8%) even though the total sum of the answers was recorded as 166, it seems 3 of the respondents preferred not to answer.

Questionnaire 15, Question 2. What is your Age?

This question was reformulated from the original sample provided to focus more on Gen Z demographics; only 1 response was left blank, and 1 responded was 30 and another response was 31 years old, with the majority of 49.7% between 22-25 years old.

Questionnaire 15, Question 3. Do you currently reside in Dublin/Ireland?

This question was reformulated from the original sample to: Do you currently reside in Dublin, as the research was limited only to the residents in Dublin/Ireland, thus 4 responses were registered as No.

Questionnaire 15, Question 6. What is your perception about online influencers when shopping online? (from 1 to 5)

From the sample, it was obvious that from the answers of the respondents, this research paper needed more in-depth information than a simple yes/no answer, and it needed to change the question and add more options, a Likert scale to choose from 1 to 5 to identify their perception.

Questionnaire 15, Question 8. Please describe a recent purchase from an online retailer.

This question was designed as an open-ended question to allow the respondents to describe their purchase in detail. Nevertheless, some responses were vague, 2 respondents skipped these questions, and overall, the responses were vague, irrelevant, making the tabulation process more difficult.

Questionnaire 15, Question 12. How effective do you believe online ads are to your purchasing decisions?

This question had to be reworded as it wasn't given clear clarification for the respondents how they should answer. For clarity reasons and to disperse future confusion, a better choice of words was given, and a Likert scale was used; even so, 1 respondent skipped to answer.

Questionnaire 15, Questions 10, 11 and 13 – these questions were skipped and not answered by all 166 respondents; only 165 answered.

Questionnaire 15, Question 14. Do you face any challenges when purchasing online products? If yes, please elaborate. If not, please elaborate.

The respondents needed constant clarification and details of the meaning of the question; that's why it was decided that the question would be reworded to avoid any future confusion and make it more understandable, thus, the adjustment improved the depth of the responses, but 3 respondents decided not to answer, only 163 responses were provided.

Questionnaire 15, Question 15. How effective do you find personalised ads in your opinion?

The initial question was rewritten to provide clear answer options, making it easier for respondents to answer; nevertheless, from 166 respondents, 1 chose to skip the question and 165 answers were provided and the end of the survey.

Appendix 2 Coding and Tabulation

1. What is your Gender?

Gender	Code	Responses	Percentage
Female	1	99	59.6%
Male	2	64	38.6%
Prefer not to say	3	3	1.8%

Note: The Majority of respondents are female, with a small percentage of 1.8% respondents who chose not to disclose their gender.

2. What is your Age?

Age Range	Code	Responses	Percentage
18-21	1	26	15.8%
22-25	2	82	49.7%
26-29	3	55	33.3%
30	4	1	0.6%
31	5	1	0.6%

Note: Majority of respondents are between 18-24

3. Do you currently reside in Dublin/Ireland?

Location	Code	Responses	Percentage
Yes	1	162	97.6%
No	2	4	2.4%

Note: Nearly all respondents currently reside in Dublin/Ireland.

4. How often do you shop online?

Frequency	Code	Responses	Percentage
Never	1	3	1.8%
A few times a year	2	50	30.1%
Monthly	3	53	31.9%
Weekly	4	58	34.9%
Daily	5	2	1.2%

Note: The majority of respondents indicated a frequent weekly shopping habit.

5. Do you prefer online shopping over in-person shopping?

Preference	Code	Responses	Percentage
Yes	1	95	57.2%
No	2	33	19.9%
Neutral	3	38	22.9%

Note: The vast majority of respondents prefer online shopping.

6. What is your perception about online influencers when shopping online? (1=Very positive, 5= Not positive)

Perception Scale	Code	Responses	Percentage
1	1	38	22.9%
2	2	37	22.3%
3	3	25	15.1%
4	4	19	11.4%
5	5	6	3.6%
Somewhat Positive	6	16	9.6%
Neutral	7	11	6.6%
Very Positive	8	9	5.4%
Somewhat Negative	9	4	2.4%
Very Negative	10	1	0.6%

Note: Most of the respondents have a Positive perception of online influencers.

7. What type of products do you buy online? (Select all that apply.)

Product Category	Code	Responses	Percentage
Clothing/Fashion	1	106	63.9%
Groceries	2	45	27.1%
Makeup/Beauty	3	85	51.2%
Accessories	4	107	64.5%
Electronics	5	77	46.4%
Other	6	65	39.2%

Note: The most bought products online are accessories.

8. Please describe a recent purchase from an online retailer

Category	Code	Responses	Percentage
Clothing/Fashion	1	30	18%
Electronics	2	25	15%
Beauty/Makeup/Skincare	3	20	12%
Accessories	4	15	9%
Home Products/Essentials	5	12	7%
Food & Groceries	6	10	6%
Books, Toys, & Games	7	8	5%
Health Products	8	5	3%
Mixed items	9	21	25%

Note: The most common purchases are Mixed items such as puzzles, thermoses, and mugs, followed closely by clothing/fashion and electronics items.

9. Where do you prefer to shop for products?

Preferences for shopping	Code	Responses	Percentage
Marketplaces	1	103	62%
Official Brand Websites	2	50	30.1%
Other Sites	3	13	7.9%

Note: The vast majority of respondents prefer Marketplaces.

10. Which factors influence your buying decisions the most? Select all that apply.

Factors	Code	Responses	Percentage
Price	1	141	85.5%
Visuals	2	86	52.1%
Security	3	56	33.9%
Reviews	4	116	70.3%
Social-Media Recommendations	5	120	72.7%

Note: Price and social media recommendations are the predominant factors that influence buying decisions.

11. How do you feel about ads during online shopping?

Feeling/Mood	Code	Responses	Percentage
Very Positive	1	21	12.7%
Positive	2	90	54.5%
Neutral	3	41	24.8%
Negative	4	13	7.9%

Note: The majority of respondents are positive towards ads when shopping online.

12. How effective do you believe online ads are to your purchasing decisions? (1= Very effective, 5= Ineffective)

Level of Effectiveness	Code	Responses	Percentage
Very Effective	1	43	26%
Effective	2	73	44.2%
Neutral	3	28	17%
Ineffective	4	15	9.1%
Very Ineffective	5	6	3.7%

Note: One Q. was left blank, and the majority of respondents agree that online ads are effective.

13. How often has an online as influenced you to buy a product?

Available Options	Code	Responses	Percentage
Always	1	37	22.4%
Sometimes	2	103	62.4%
Almost never	3	21	12.7%
Never	4	4	2.4%

Note: The majority of respondents are influenced by ads when shopping online.

14. Do you face any challenges when purchasing online products? If yes, please elaborate; if not, please elaborate.

Types of Responses	Code	Responses	Percentage
No challenges/Easy to shop online	1	65	39.4%
Delivery delays/waiting time	2	18	10.9%
Data privacy/security concerns	3	15	9.1%
Incorrect product size	4	14	8.5%
Quality concerns	5	12	7.3%
Refund difficulties/issues	6	9	5.5%
Fake reviews	7	8	4.8%
Trustworthiness regarding websites	8	7	4.2%
Too many choices	9	6	3.6%
Influencers doubt/uncertainty	10	5	3%
Price difference across websites	11	3	1.8%
Other (unique challenges)	12	8	4.8%

Note: The vast majority of respondents are confident when shopping online, only small concerns on delivery delays and security concerns as well as size and quality of the products.

15. How effective do you find personalised ads in your opinion?

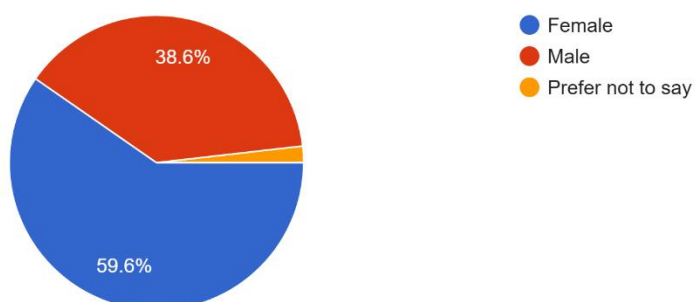
Level of Effectiveness	Code	Responses	Percentage
Effective	1	82	49.7%
Somehow effective	2	58	35.2%
Neutral	3	20	12.1%
Ineffective	4	5	3%

Note: Almost 50% of respondents consider personalised ads to be effective.

Appendix 3, Graph and Charts of the Online Questionnaire

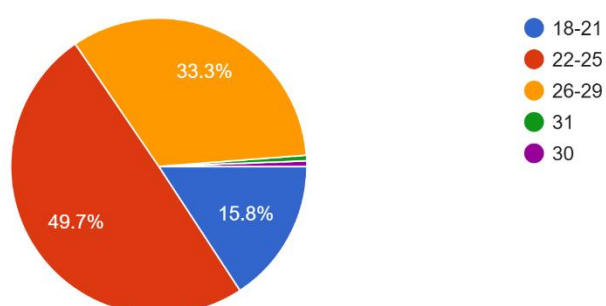
1. What is your Gender?

166 responses



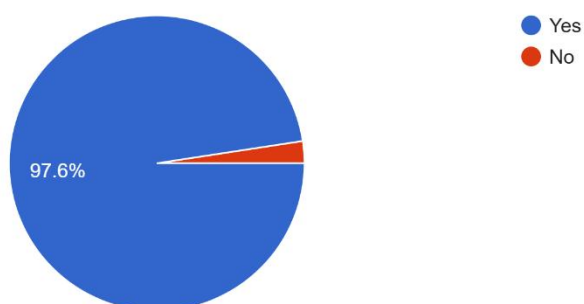
2. What is your Age?

165 responses



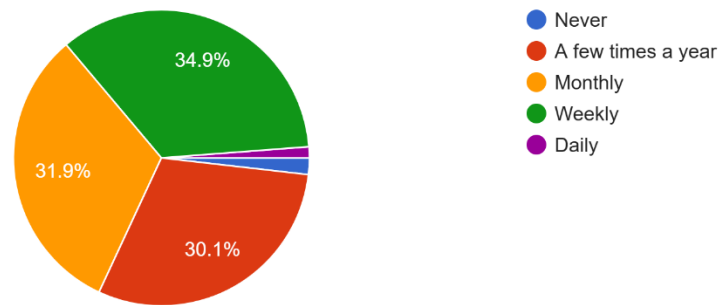
3. Do you currently reside in Dublin/Ireland?

166 responses



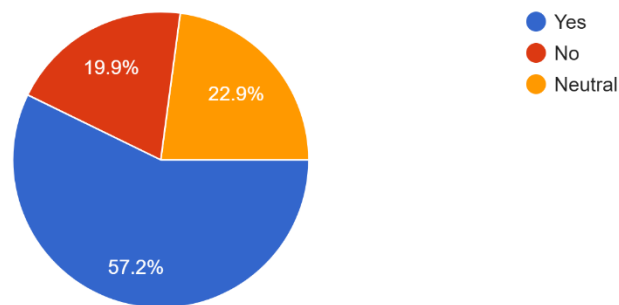
4. How often do you shop online?

166 responses



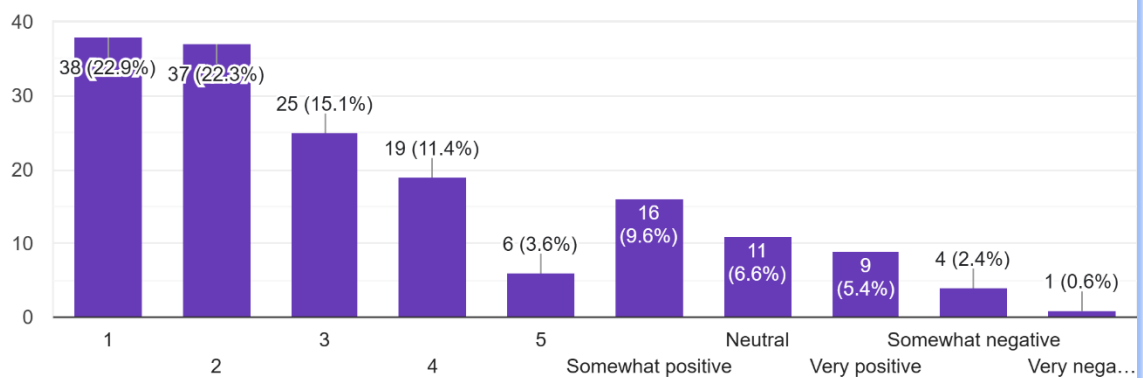
5. Do you prefer online shopping over in-person shopping?

166 responses



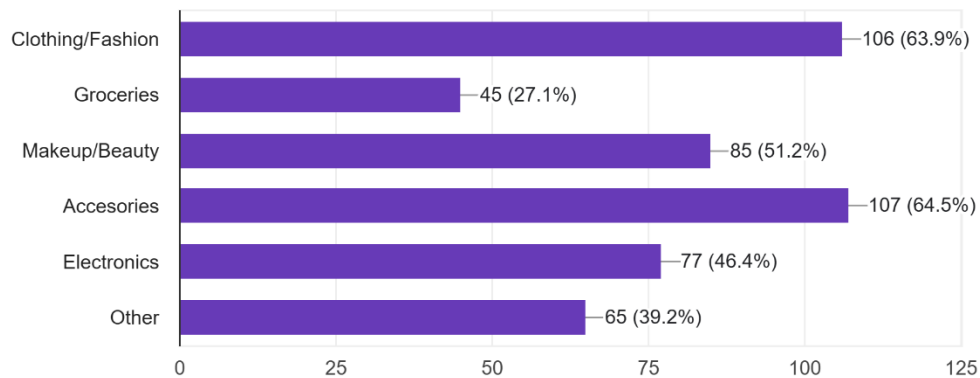
6. What is your perception about online influencers when shopping online? (from 1 to 5)

166 responses



7. What type of products do you buy online? (Select all that apply)

166 responses



8. Please describe a recent purchase from an online retailer. 164 responses

a watch from Amazon

Makeup from Boots

I got a dress from Amazon for a birthday party.

Perfume

New clothes

I did my weekly shopping from Tesco and got delivered at my door, fast.

I always order food online, so almost every week I shop online. (Deliveroo)

From Temu a belt

Electronics stuff from Amazon

The last thing I bought was a Ukulele online.

Leather Wallet from TKMAX.

Phone cover from amazon

From Boots, make-up

Victoria's Secret pyjamas from their website.

wallpaper stickers from Temu.

Adidas Shoes

From Shein, some dresses and T-shirts for summer

Clothes

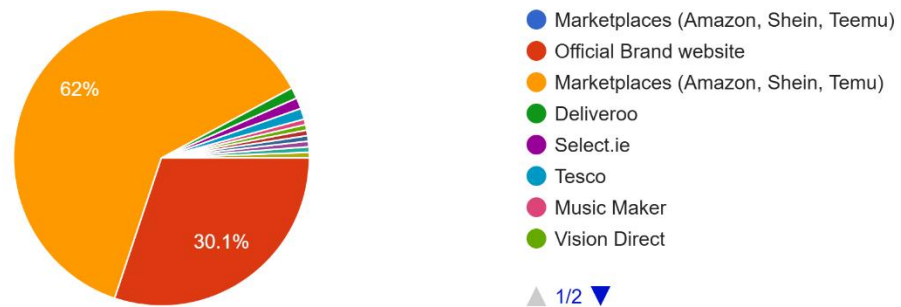
From Amazon a wallet

There are 164 responses, The Survey link is provided:

<https://forms.gle/o3avMAohqDEcA3UZ9>

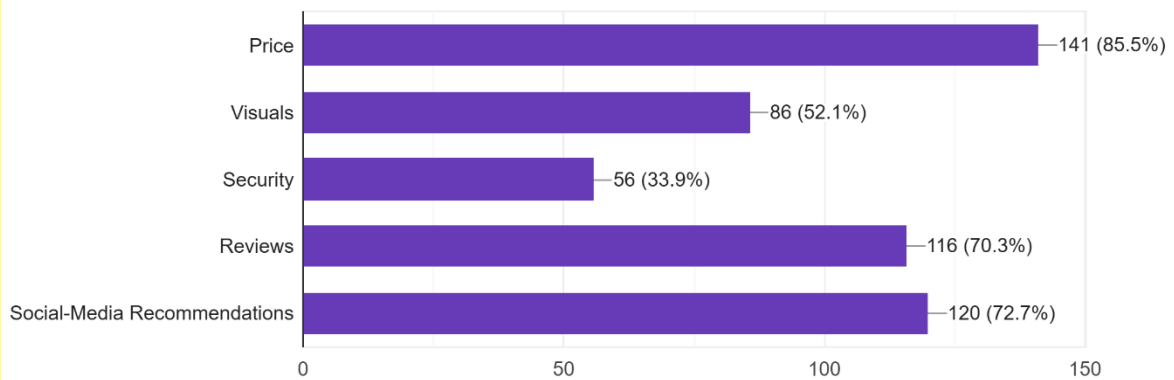
9. Where do you prefer to shop for products?

166 responses



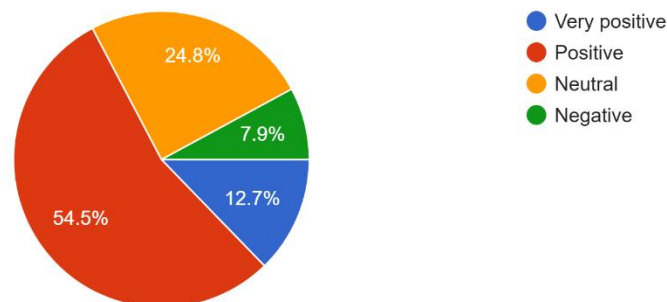
10. Which factors influence your buying/purchasing decisions the most? Select all that apply.

165 responses



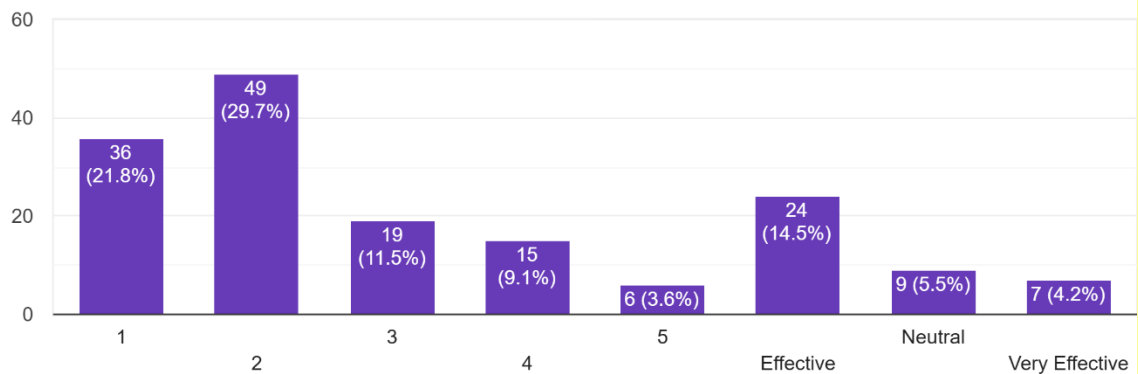
11. How do you feel about ads during online shopping?

165 responses



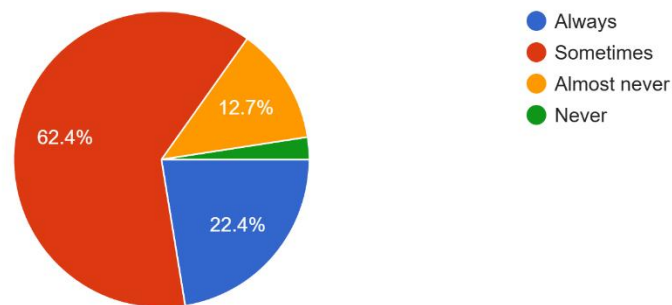
12. How effective do you believe online ads are to your purchasing decisions?

165 responses



13. How often has an online ad influenced you to buy a product?

165 responses



14. Do you face any challenges when purchasing online products? If yes, please elaborate. If not, please elaborate. 163 responses

no

No challenge; it's easy

It's easy to shop online

No challenges, in my opinion; it tends to be easier to get something sent to your house.

Scams

No, I find it easy.

No. As long as it's a trusty website, I don't see any problems.

There is no challenge, anyone can shop online nowadays.

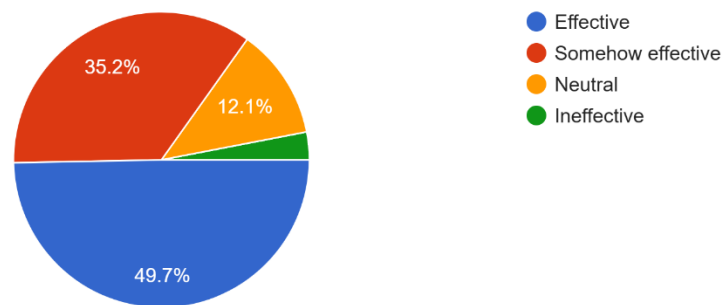
I'm not sure about the security and quality

There are 163 responses; the link to the Survey is provided:

<https://forms.gle/o3avMAohqDEcA3UZ9>

15. How effective do you find personalised ads in your opinion?

165 responses



This is the link for the Online Questionnaire: <https://forms.gle/o3avMAohqDEcA3UZ9>

Appendix 4 Individual Contribution

Student Name: Hellen Campos Rodrigues

Student Number: 10615747

As part of our capstone project, The Influence of Digital Marketing on Consumer Behaviour: A Study of Gen Z Purchasing Trends in E-commerce- RETAIL in Dublin,

I had the honour to work with my team, and I had significant roles with multiple different tasks to achieve our main goal in this study, which is to demonstrate the background of the problem and bring suggestions and recommendations based on the Literature Review and the online survey conducted, as well as answer the research questions and objectives. One of my key contributions to the capstone project was:

1. Helping to find enough participants from the right audience, which is Generation Z, to answer our survey, as well as study the answers to shape the key findings of this project.
2. I was also involved in structuring and writing different sections of this study, such as: Acknowledgements, abstract, objectives of work, methodology used, main findings, finding conclusions, brief of recommendations, introduction, background of the problem, scope and limitation of the research project, which makes my contribution evident to the project.

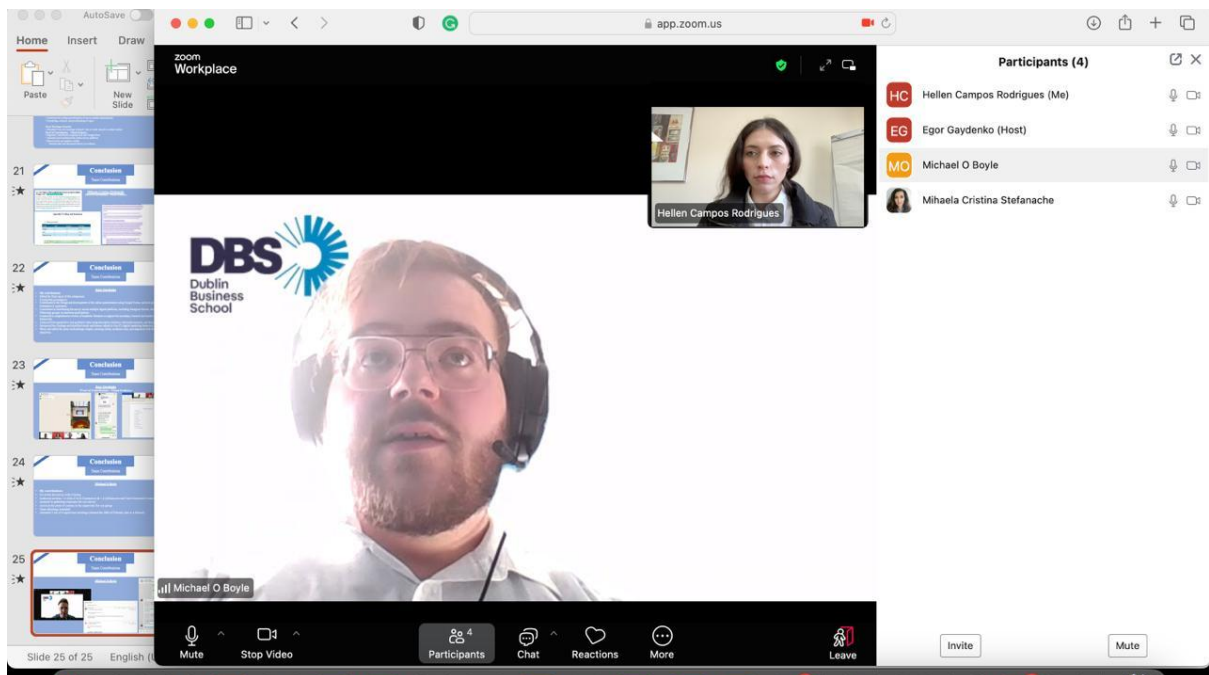
Working on this project and sections has been a memorable experience since it allowed me to gain different experiences and perspectives on how Gen Z perceive certain brands and online shopping in Ireland, it helped me to understand and identify certain patterns we have in common when shopping online and how businesses can better target this demographic more effectively. Participating to the coordinator meetings helped me to understand how a capstone is written within a group and how we should collaborate as a team to achieve success in the capstone project. I attended all four project meetings with our coordinator Linda Moran.

All the knowledge I have gained through this project will be valuable for my career when it comes to critical thinking, research, trends, data analysis, and academic writing.

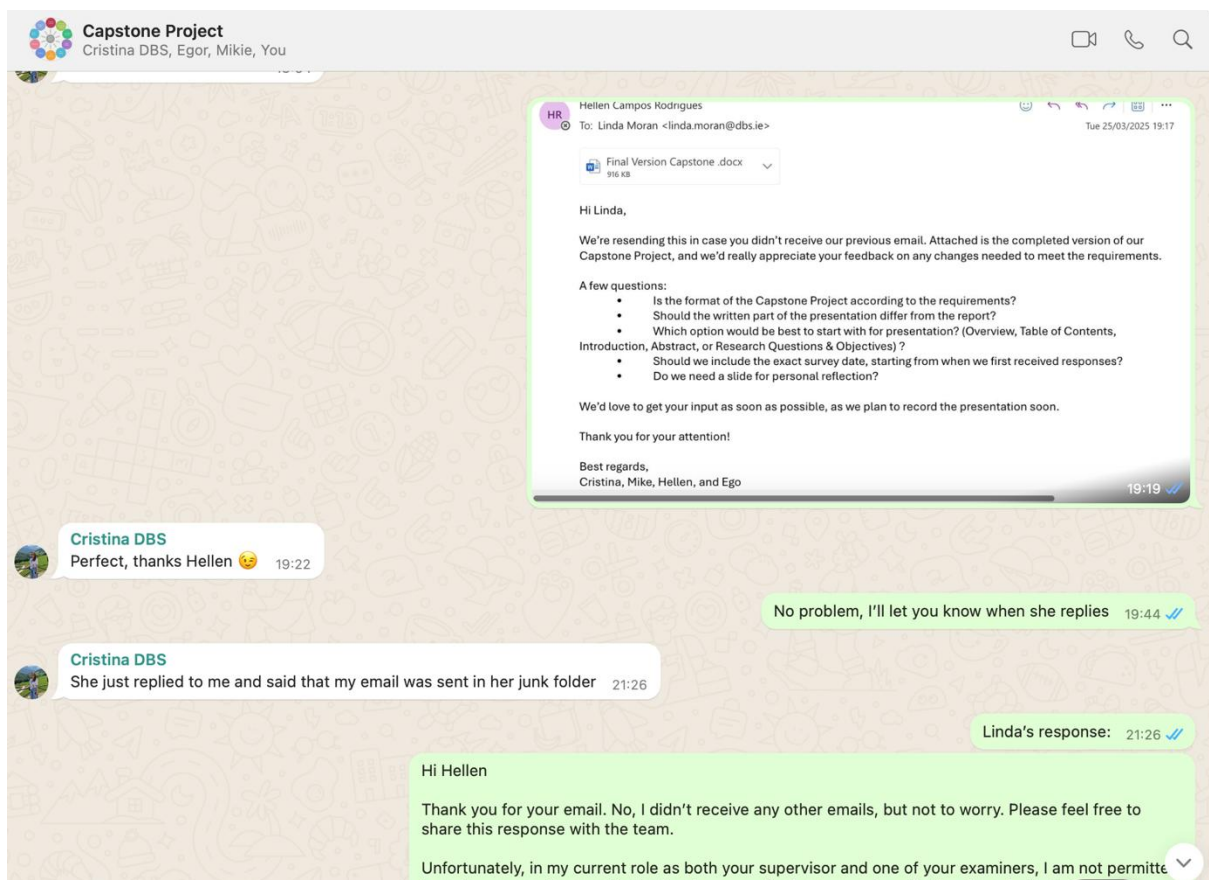
Working with my team has been an enhancing experience from the beginning and I express all my gratitude to them and all my lectures at Dublin Business School.

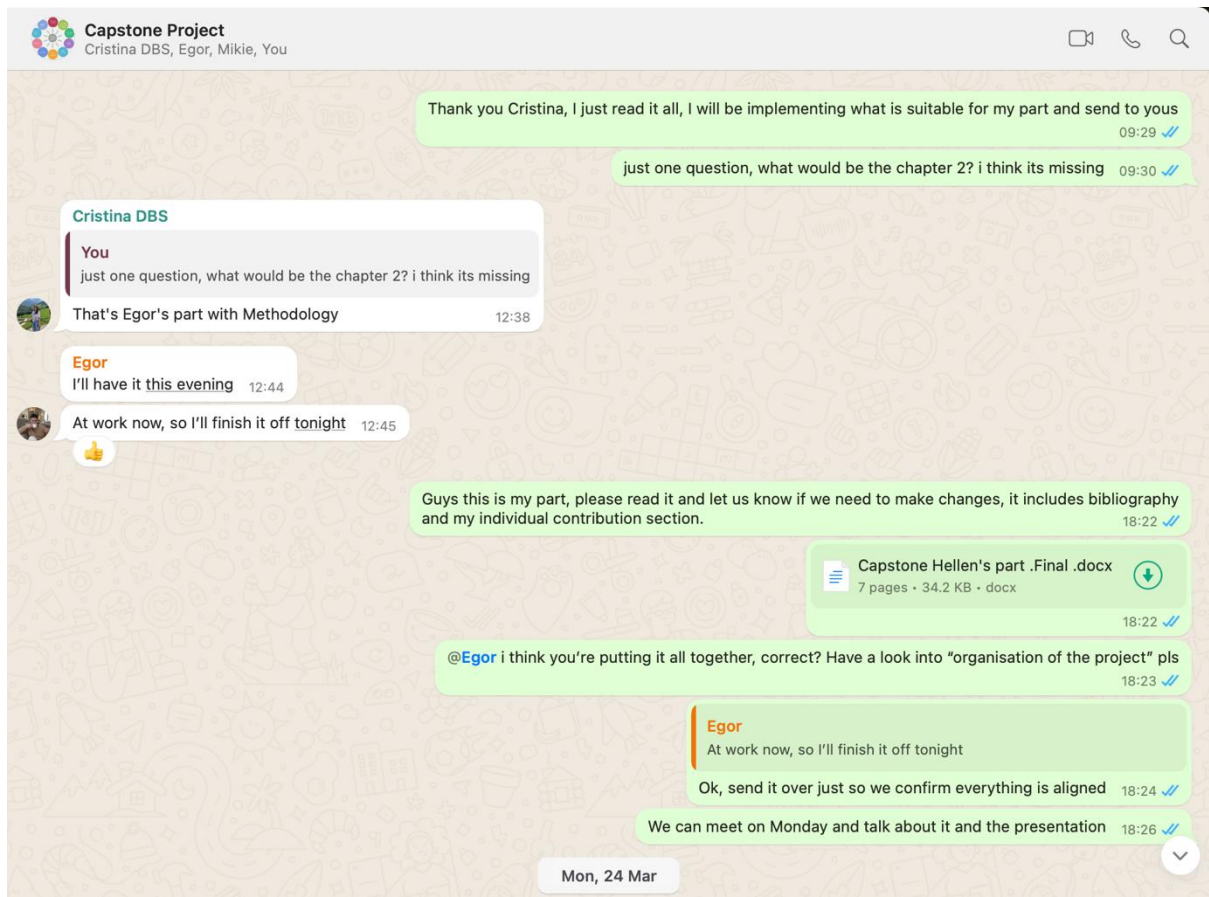
Visual Contributions:

Team meetings:



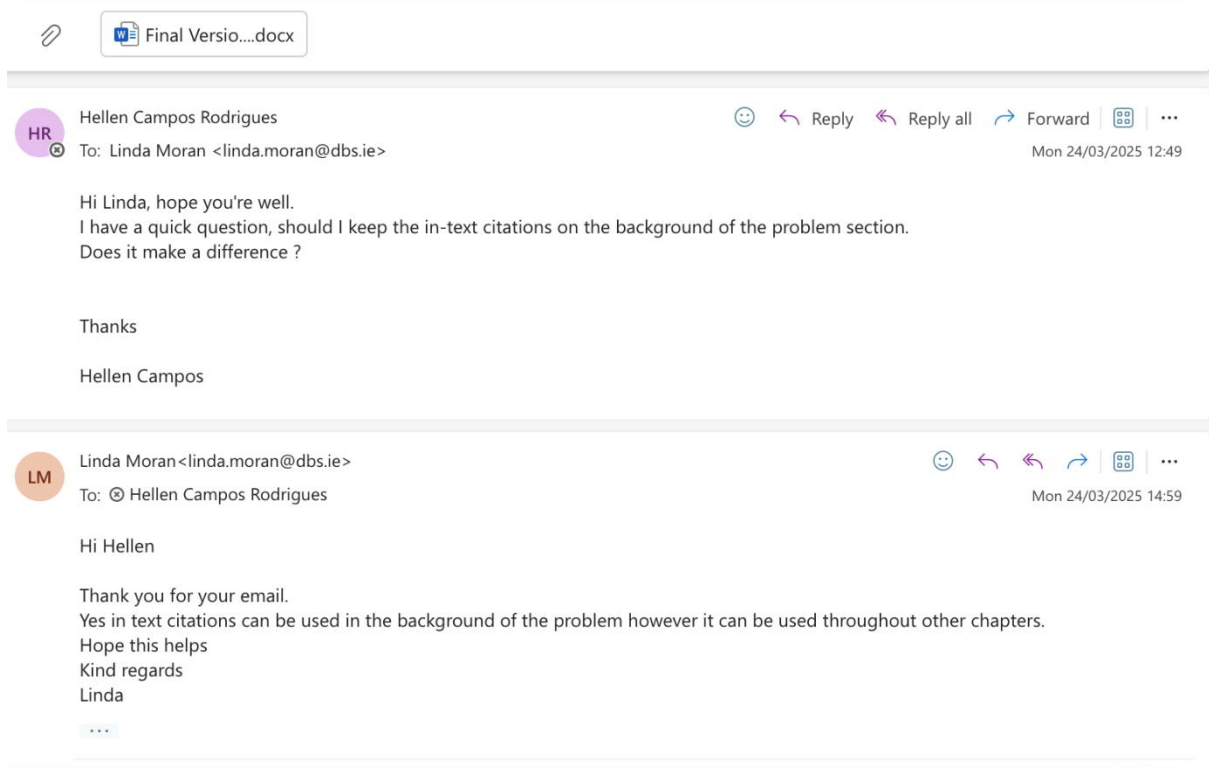
WhatsApp Group Communication & Contributions :





Contacting Coordinator:

Background of the problem



Student Name: Mihaela Cristina Stefanache

Student Number: 10633446

This Learning Log will outline my contribution to the research paper titled and stated above. My contribution will be demonstrated and highlighted, and I will reflect on the work completed on this Capstone Project.

Creating and Managing the Online Survey

One of my contributions started with creating the 15 survey questions. This task was shared with one of my colleagues, Mikie. Together, we carefully designed the questionnaire to align with our research objectives and to catch the necessary data regarding Gen Z's purchasing trends in e-commerce retail in Dublin. After we finished the initial questions, I took the responsibility for uploading the Survey on Google Forms, as well I ensured that it will be accessible to participants. I managed all subsequent editing and revisions of questions to maintain the clarity and structure where it could be improved, ensuring that the survey remained effective and engaging.

Literature Review Contribution

I played a key role in writing the Introduction section of the First Chapter, Literature review. This section needed to provide the reader with key themes, trends and fundamental concepts related to digital marketing and Gen Z's purchasing behaviour. The whole Chapter of the Literature Review was divided between me and my colleague, Mikie.

My specific contribution includes two critical sections:

1.3. The Impact of Personalized Advertising on Gen Z's Brand Engagement – In this section, I explored the way personalized marketing influences the loyalty, thrust and purchase behaviour of Gen Z.

1.5. Transparency and Ethical Digital Marketing Practices for Gen Z – This section examined how ethical marketing practices, for example, data privacy, transparency and true and honest marketing influence and impact Gen Z’s engagement with the brands. In this Chapter, I also wrote the Conclusion of the Literature Review, where I had to summarise key insights and connect them with the research Objectives. To write these, I had to synthesize my work and my colleague's work, Mikie, so that I ensure a unified (cohesive) structure of the Conclusion section in a correct way.

Data Analysis and Hypothesis

In this Chapter, I had an important contribution being the solo writer. Coding of the survey answers to clarify and structure the data. Tabulation of the Survey: I organized the data into tables, and visual representation was crucial for me to identify the patterns, correlations and key insights from the data to test the proposed hypothesis, ensuring alignment with our research objectives. The coding and tabulation to my initiative I kept them in one table as the data was easier to read and interpret.

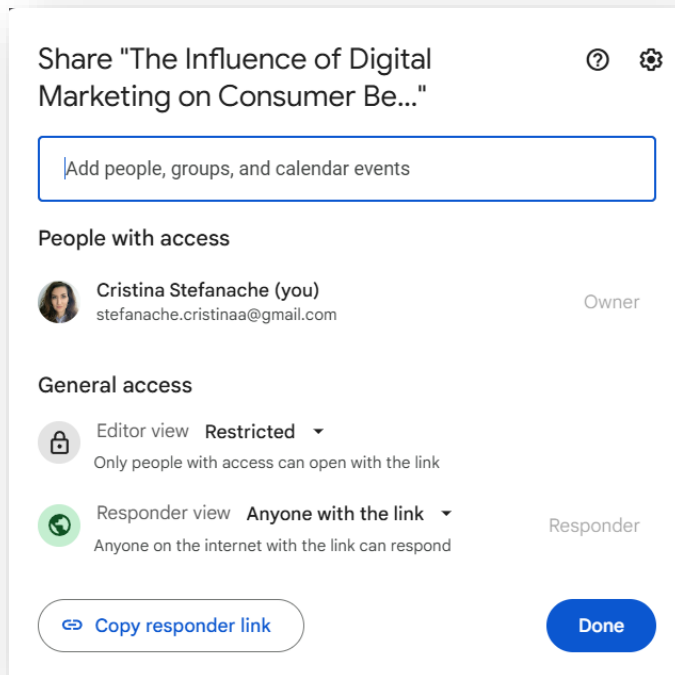
Conclusion and Recommendations

In this Chapter, I was the sole writer, and my contribution was implied in summarising the key findings from the research, linking the data analysis results to the initial research objectives. I also offered recommendations for future market strategies for retailers in Dublin for future implementation and improvements in the marketing strategies to attract Gen Z consumers. I had a better understanding of Gen Z beliefs and purchasing behaviour in e-commerce. The data collected demonstrated and showed these behaviours; because of that, I recommended the marketers emphasize personalized ads, improve transparency and ethical marketing practices to gain and retain Gen Z.

Demonstrating my Contribution-Visual Proof

My contribution to this Capstone project can be seen through various forms of evidence:

1. **Google Forms Survey Logs** – The platform records can identify me as the account holder responsible for uploading and editing the Survey.



Share "The Influence of Digital Marketing on Consumer Behavior"

Add people, groups, and calendar events

People with access

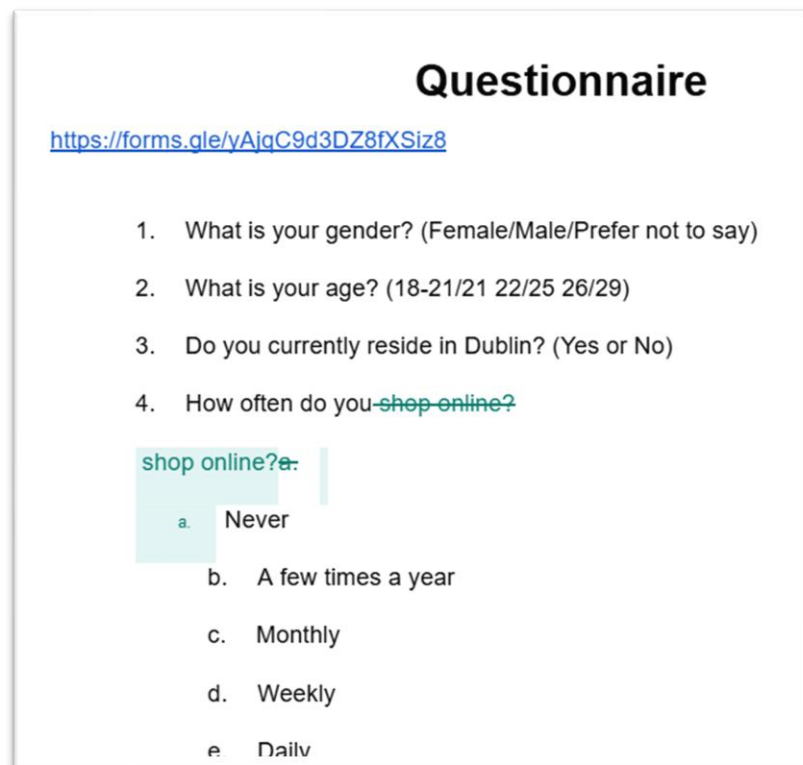
 **Cristina Stefanache (you)**
stefanache.cristinaa@gmail.com Owner

General access

 Editor view **Restricted** ▼
Only people with access can open with the link

 Responder view **Anyone with the link** ▼ Responder
Anyone on the internet with the link can respond

[Copy responder link](#) [Done](#)



Questionnaire

<https://forms.gle/yAjQc9d3DZ8fXSiz8>

1. What is your gender? (Female/Male/Prefer not to say)
2. What is your age? (18-21/21 22/25 26/29)
3. Do you currently reside in Dublin? (Yes or No)
4. How often do you ~~shop online?~~ **shop online?**
a. Never
b. A few times a year
c. Monthly
d. Weekly
e. Daily

2. Document History: A Google Document and WhatsApp group were created where shared documents, including my work, can be demonstrated.

Questionnaire

1. What is your gender?

2. What is your age?

3. Do you live in Dublin??= Yes or No

4. How often do you shop online?

a. Never

b. A few times a year

c. Monthly

d. Weekly

e. Constantly

5. Do you prefer shopping online to shopping in person?

a. Yes

b. No

c. Neutral

6. Do you feel negatively or positively about influencers when shopping online?

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Hellen Campos

February 28, 10:09 AM

Cristina Stefanache

Hellen Campos

February 28, 9:20 AM

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February 27, 10:48 PM

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February 17, 11:06 AM

Cristina Stefanache

February 11, 1:31 PM

Cristina Stefanache

February 10, 1:09 PM

Cristina Stefanache

Show changes

Questionnaire

1. What is your gender? (Female/Male/Prefer not to say)

2. What is your age? (18-21/21 22/25 26/29)

3. Do you live in Dublin??= Yes or No currently reside in Dublin? (Yes or No)

4. How often do you shop online?

a. Never

b. A few times a year

c. Monthly

d. Weekly

e. Constantly/Daily

5. Do you prefer shopping online to shopping in person?

a. Yes

b. No

c. Neutral

6. Do you feel negatively or positively about influencers?What is your perception about online influencers when shopping online? (Please elaborate: positive, somewhat positive, neutral, negative)

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the e-commerce landscape. This analysis examines how several social media platforms, a mounting number of targeted advertisements and many influencers help Generation Z. These factors influence how this generation connects with brands and makes purchasing decisions. Furthermore, it emphasizes several psychological and emotional factors that influence their online purchase decisions, assessing how these factors correlate with an important number of larger trends in personalization as well as data-driven marketing.

Existing studies offer several important understandings into the effectiveness of digital marketing strategies. This exploration provides a considerably strong theoretical foundation for examining the complex and ever-changing relationship between digital marketing and Gen Z's e-commerce behavior; furthermore, this review will pinpoint important areas that necessitate more thorough empirical investigation:

1.1 Introduction to the Literature Review

Digital marketing has fundamentally transformed/adapted how consumers interact with brands, particularly among Generation Z, a demographic that has grown up in an era of unprecedented technological advancement. With a strong preference for digital interactions, Gen Z relies heavily on online platforms, personalized advertising, and social proof (reviews) when purchasing. This shift has significantly impacted e-commerce retail, particularly in Dublin, where digital engagement is a dominant force shaping consumer behavior.

This literature review explores the role of social media platforms, personalized advertising, influencers, and ethical digital marketing practices in shaping Gen Z's brand engagement and purchase decisions in the online retail sector. The discussion is structured around four key themes:

- Gen Z as Digital Natives in E-Commerce Retail – Examining how platforms like Instagram, TikTok, and Facebook influence Gen Z's purchasing habits.
- The Impact of Personalized Advertising on Brand Engagement – Understanding how targeted ads shape loyalty, trust, and purchase intent.
- Influencers and User Generated Content in Gen Z's Purchasing Decisions – Analyzing

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Capstone Project

1.3. The Impact of Personalized Advertising on Gen Z's Brand Engagement - Cristina

- Searching how targeted and personalized ads influence Gen Z's relationship with brands, including their loyalty and trust.
- Understanding the psychological and emotional effects of personalized advertisements on their purchasing intent.
- Focus: How personalized advertising shapes Gen Z's brand loyalty and trust, focusing on psychological and emotional responses to tailored ads. [20241017155600.pdf](#)

Personalised advertising has become a strong form of marketing, especially for Generation Z, a demographic known for their way with technology, lifestyle and their love of personalised experiences. Through data-driven insights and AI, brands can create targeted ads that align with user preferences and interests, resulting in more relevant and engaging marketing messaging. However, while personalized ads can boost brand loyalty and trust, they can also feel pushy, leading to privacy concerns and scepticism. (Reddy et al., 2024)

1.3.1. Positive Impacts of Personalized Advertising on Gen Z's Brand Engagement

1.3.2. Increased Relevance and Engagement

According to studies from Astuti & Putra (2023), we can see that Gen Z interacts with brands more often and is receptive to ads when they are personalized and tailored to their interest and needs. Another study from Tran et al., (2022) confirms that when the ad is done right, this personalized ad will lead to an emotional connection with the brand, thus making the brand feel relevant to the consumer.

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Capstone Project

1.5. Transparency and Ethical Digital Marketing Practices for Gen Z - Cristina

When it comes to Brand transparency and ethical data, Gen Z is one of the most informed and aware groups that values ethical marketing. These generations have high expectations when it comes to how these brands are using their personal data, the confidentiality and moral aspect that comes with it, compared to the last generations. If brands fail to be transparent, Gen Z is more likely to lose trust and leave. (Balangcas, 2023) This section explores how ethical digital marketing practices influence Gen Z's trust and loyalty.

1.5.1. Challenges & Risks of Personalized Advertising

1.5.2. Data Transparency & Consumer Trust

Research from Hoang (et al., 2022) & Dahl and Peltier (2023) showed that Gen Z prefers brands that clearly state how they use data, and over-targeted ads can make them feel like brands are tracking them too closely, leading to discomfort and lower trust. Brands that have transparent policies have a better chance of succeeding and gaining (retaining) customers as well as building strong and longer relationships in the long term. On the other hand, those brands that use hidden methods of retaining and tracking information will backlash and be confronted with negative reactions. (Dahl and Peltier 2023)

Version history

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3.1. Introduction - Cristina's Contribution

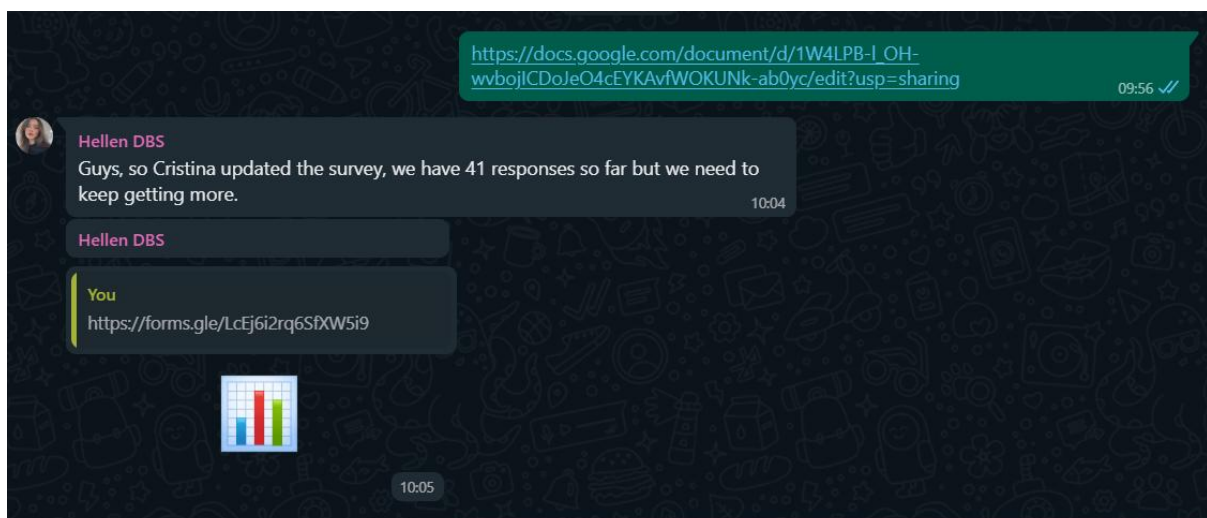
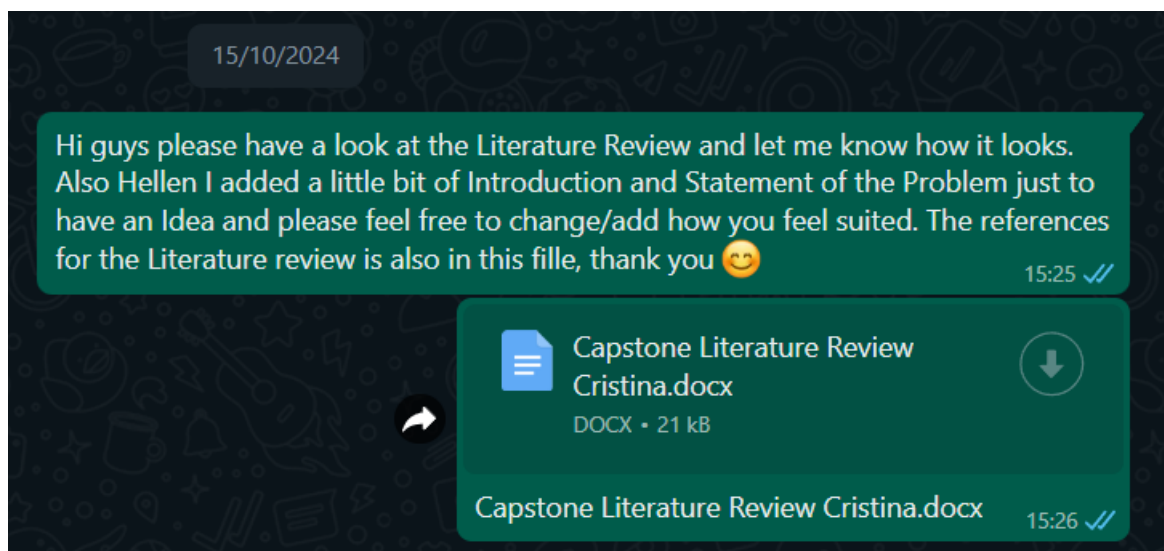
This chapter will present the findings from the online Questionnaire and the Data collected will offer perspective on the attitude and behaviour of Gen Z's generation towards digital marketing and e-commerce. The Data collected will reveal trends and behaviours in their shopping habits, preference for personalized ads and their trust in the influencers and brands. These results will be analysed and revised together with the Literature review to identify any correlations and bring evidence which will support or contest the Objectives and Hypothesis stated.

3.2. Research Objective 1: To explore how social media platforms influence purchasing decisions among Gen Z consumers

The Questionnaire Data, especially Q.4, Q9 and Q.10 it shows/reveals that social media platforms have a direct influence towards their shopping behaviour. These data confirm the literature review from Lapidus et al. (2024) that stated the fact that Gen Z relies heavily on social media platforms to discover new trends, products and brands. Furthermore, these data indicate that platforms like Instagram and TikTok are key factors in promoting fashion, beauty and lifestyle among Gen Z consumers as the visual content, influencers' recommendations and online reviews were mentioned as the main factors when purchasing online, factors also reflected in studies by Baghel (2023) (Please see Appendix 2, Questionnaire for more details)

1.3. The Impact of Personalized Advertising on Gen Z's Brand Engagement - Cristina'S Contribution

Personalised advertising has become one of the stronger ~~tools~~ marketing tools/strategies used by marketers, especially for Generation Z, a demographic known for their way with technology, lifestyle and their love of personalised experiences. ~~Through~~By using data-driven insights and AI, brands can create targeted/tailored ads that align with user preferences and interests, resulting in more relevant and engaging marketing messaging- as well as better revenue. However, while personalized ads can boost brand loyalty and trust, they can also feel pushy, intrusive that can leading to privacy concerns and scepticism-, losing the consumer thrust. (Reddy et.al., 2024)

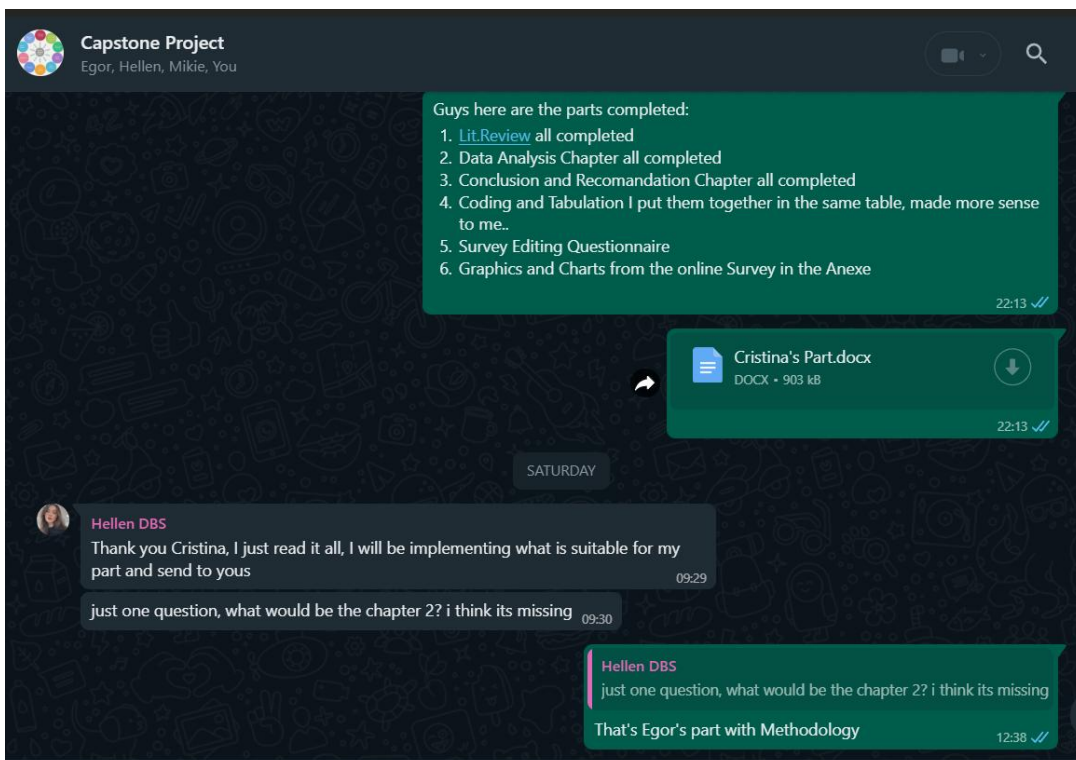
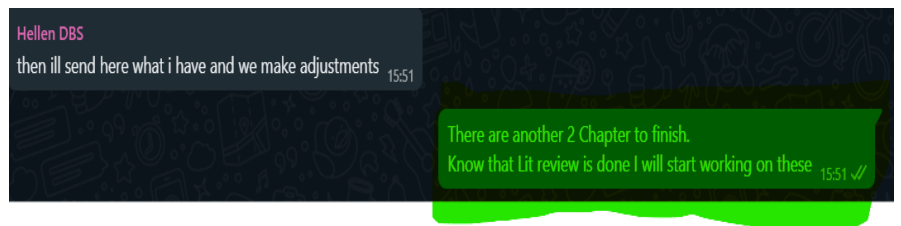
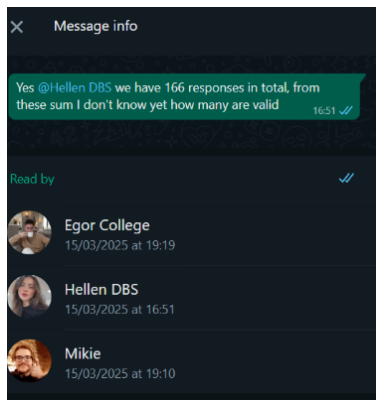


Appendix 2 Coding and Tabulation

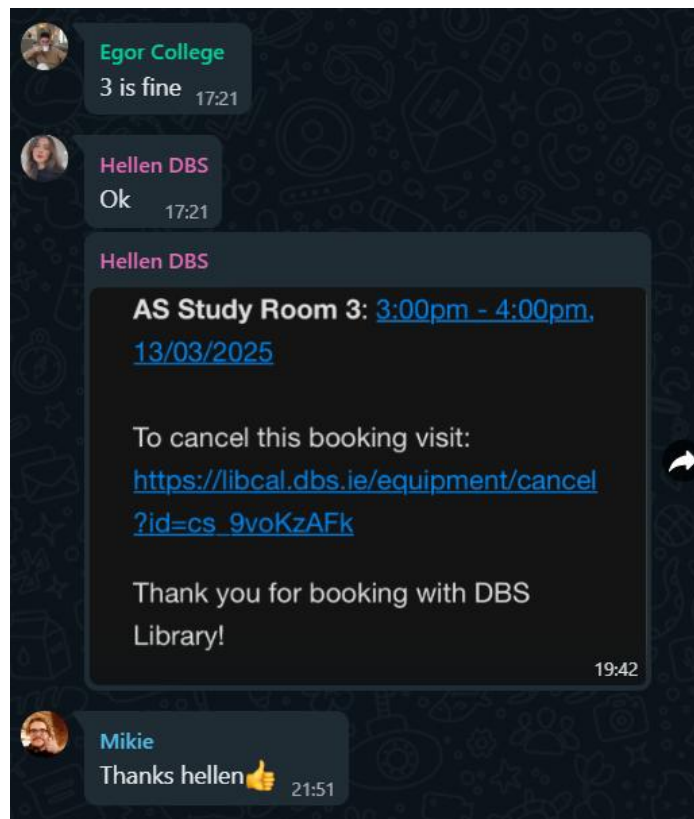
1. What is your Gender?

Gender	Code	Responses	Percentage
Female	1	99	59.66%
Male	2	64	38.6%
Prefer not to say	3	3	1.8%

Note: The Majority of ~~respondents~~ responses/respondents are female, with a small and a small percentage of 1.8% respondents who chose not to disclose their gender.



3. **Meeting Notes:** Library meeting notes, as well as WhatsApp record messages of group discussions where my contribution was acknowledged by team members, are available.

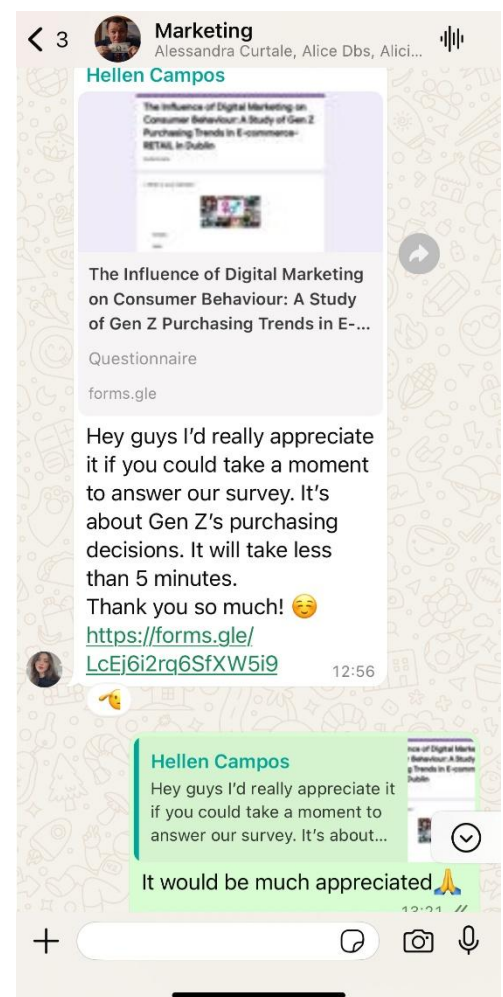
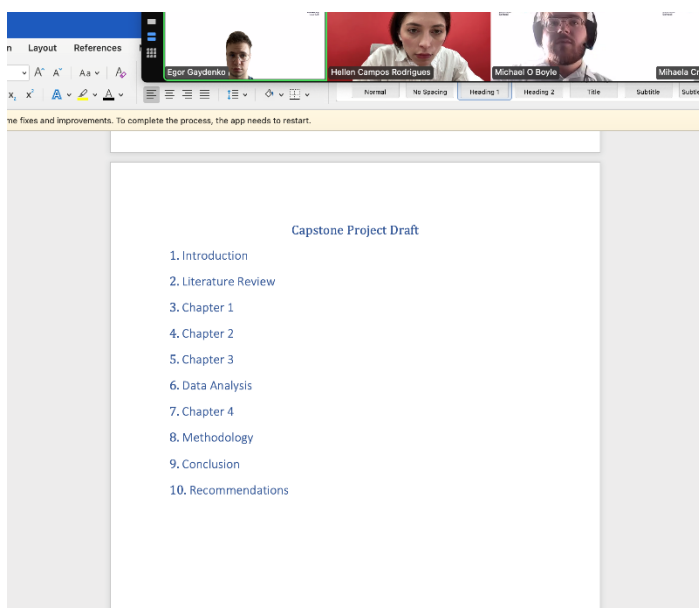
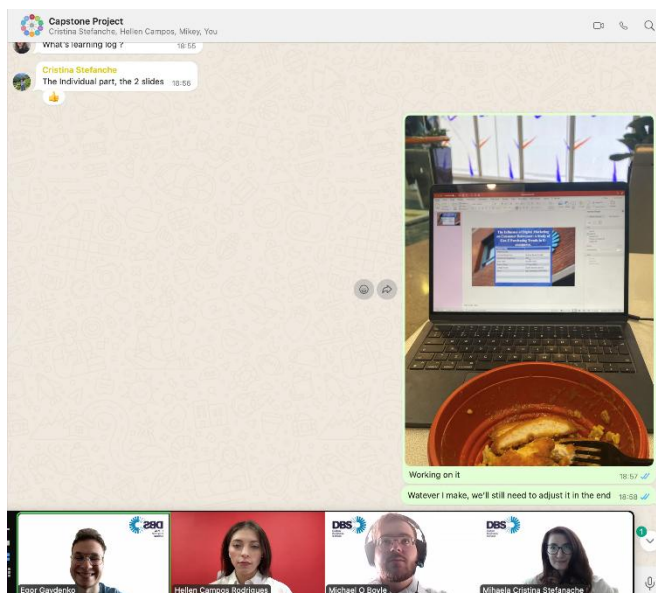


Being a part of this team on this Capstone Projects allowed me to develop several key skills, including effective communication, data analysis and time management. The mixture of sole writing and sharing tasks improved my capacity of managing multiple elements in the Project in an efficient way. Overall, my contribution played a significant role in this assignment, combining both practical and theoretical insights, ensuring the paper had solid data.

Student Name: Egor Gaydenko

Student Number: 10620320

In this assignment, I made several key contributions that significantly supported both the research and the final deliverables. I also created the accompanying presentation to visually communicate our key findings. I helped distribute the survey across various digital platforms such as Instagram Stories, direct messages, and WhatsApp groups, to maximise participation and reach. For the secondary research, I reviewed academic literature to support our theoretical framework. From this, I identified key findings and trends in Gen Z's digital marketing behaviour. I also wrote and edited the methodology chapter, making sure it was clear, well-structured, and matched our research goals.



Student Name: Michael O Boyle
Student Number: 10620116

My two main contributions to the report were the primary research and the literature review. After deciding on our method of primary research, I co-wrote the survey we used. After helping plan and separate the work, I wrote sections 1.2 (Gen Z as Digital Natives in E-Commerce Retail Fashion) and 1.4 of the literature review (Influencers and User-Generated Content in Gen Z's Purchasing Decisions).

Another role I had in the capstone project was acting as a point of contact between our group and Linda Moran, our capstone supervisor. I sent her our original capstone proposal and helped up correspondence between her and our group. I also assisted in gathering responses for our primary research, using social media to spread our survey to a wider audience. The experience of working on this capstone project has helped me greatly in developing my skills for further work. It has developed my communication, organisation and teamwork skills. My group has been incredibly professional and efficient in its work, and I feel extremely lucky to have worked with them. I am also thankful for the assistance of our capstone supervisor, who helped us put together the final report.



